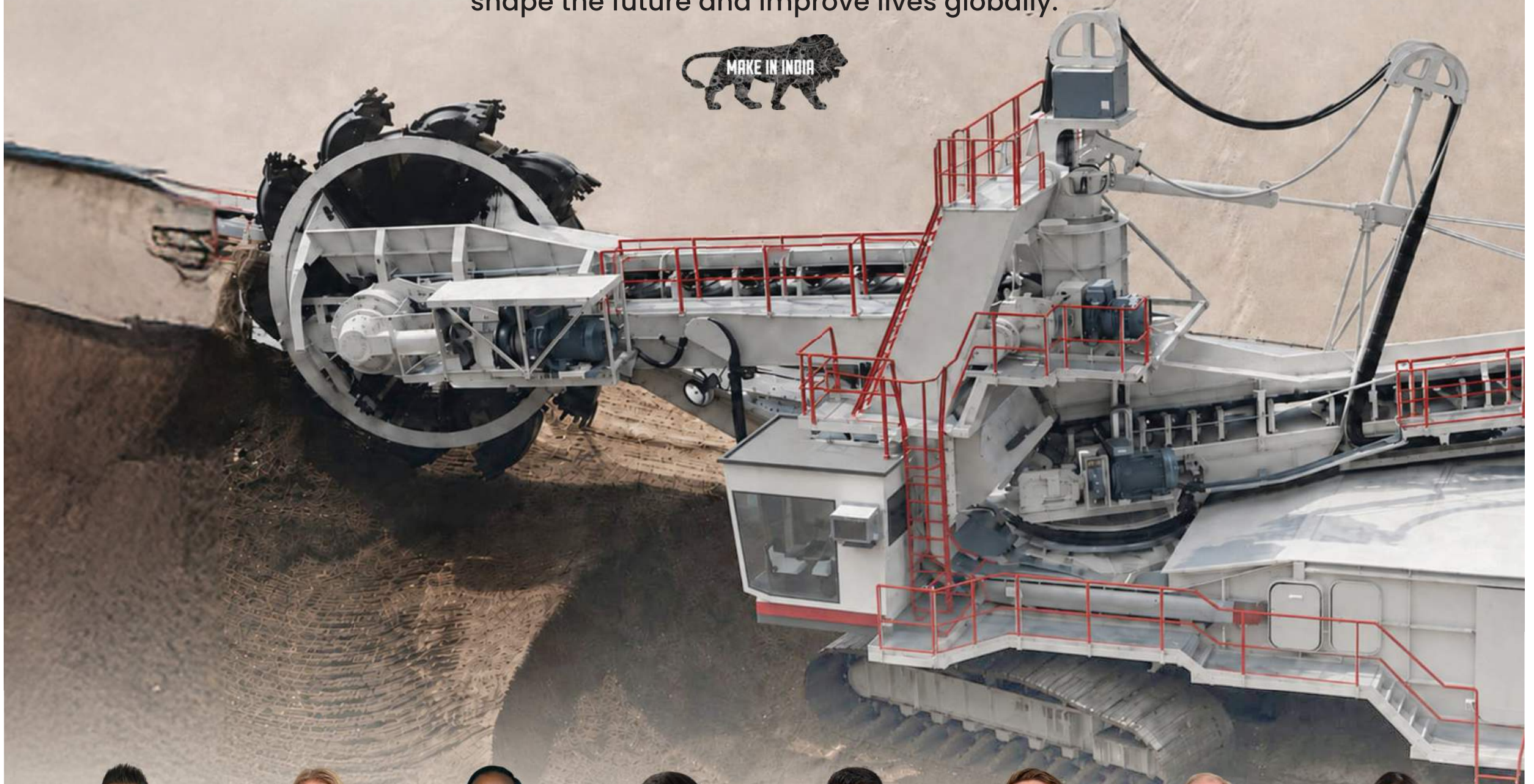




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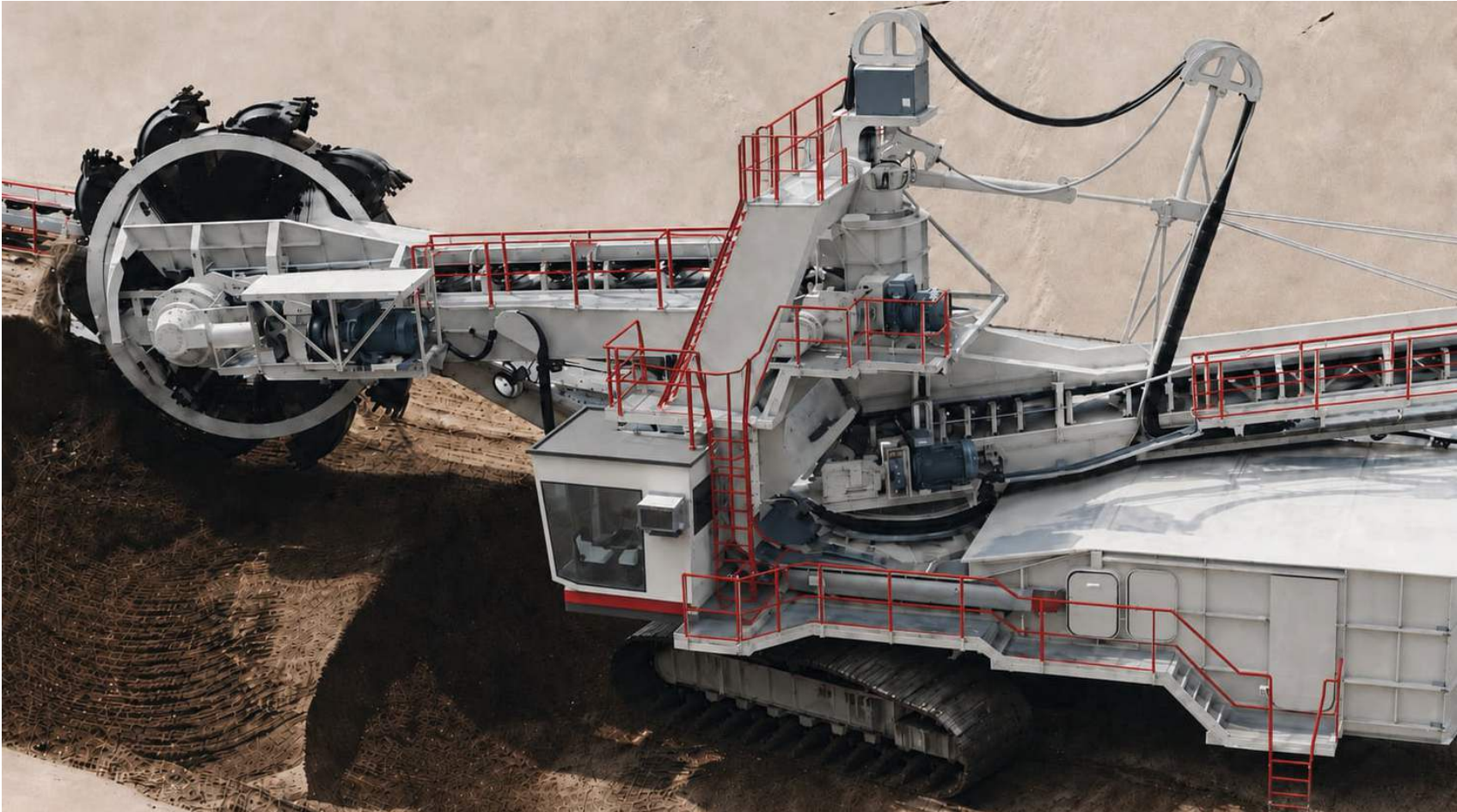
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BLOC CONDEMNS PAHALGAM TERROR ATTACK

BRICS Adopts New Delhi Declaration by Consensus, Navigates Iran-UAE Divide

Calls for civilian protection, backs nuclear-free West Asia amid tensions in the region

Dipanjn Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: The BRICS on Saturday adopted the Joint Declaration (New Delhi Declaration) by consensus, overcoming differences between Iran and the UAE. The group also suggested the establishment of a zone free of nuclear weapons and other weapons of mass destruction in the Middle East amid fears of attacks on civilian nuclear facilities in the region.

The BRICS states expressed deep concern over the continued escalation of tensions in the Middle East/ West Asia and, recalling respective national positions, called for exercising maximum restraint and avoiding actions that could further aggravate the situation.

“...we urge to ensure the protection of civilians and civilian infrastructure in accordance with the purposes and principles of the Charter of the United Nations in their entirety...” the declaration stressed, reflecting the views of both Iran and the UAE.

“We encourage increasing efforts, through dialogue and diplomacy, towards a long-term understanding that will contribute to lasting peace, security and stability in the region. Westress the need to work together to maintain smooth flow of global trade, supply chains and energy, in accordance with applicable international law,” the member states noted amid the West Asian War and Strait of Hormuz blockade that has impacted the flow of global trade.



nal law,” the member states noted amid the West Asian War and Strait of Hormuz blockade that has impacted the flow of global trade.

The formulation that led to the

STRETCHING INTO WEE HOURS



Negotiations among member states continued until the early hours of Saturday to reach consensus

adoption of the New Delhi Declaration was not easily arrived at. In the run-up to the Summit, the BRICS Foreign Ministers’ and Trade Ministers’ meetings could not achieve a joint declaration due to differences between Iran and the UAE amid the conflict. ET had reported earlier this week that BRICS Sherpas had intensified discussions to reach consensus, narrowing down differences between the few members. Negotiations continued until the early hours of Saturday to reach consensus.

The BRICS member states condemned the imposition of unilateral coercive measures that are contrary to international law, and reiterated that such measures,

inter alia in the form of unilateral economic sanctions and secondary sanctions, have far-reaching negative implications. The BRICS members backing India’s position expressed strong condemnation of any acts of terrorism.

“We condemn in the strongest terms the terrorist attack in J&K on 22 April 2025, during which 26 people were killed. We reaffirm our commitment to combating terrorism in all its forms and manifestations, including the cross-border movement of terrorists, terrorism financing and safe havens.”



MODI MEETS UAE CROWN PRINCE, MALAYSIAN PM

Modi, Al Nahyan Look to UAE Fund for India Projects

Modi, Anwar bin Ibrahim review semiconductor coop and bilateral ties

Dipanjn Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday discussed the role that I’lad, the UAE’s new sovereign investment fund, could play in further widening the India-UAE partnership with Abu Dhabi Crown Prince Sheikh Khalid bin Mohamed here on the margins of the BRICS Summit. They also discussed opportunities to enhance cooperation in strategic and emerging areas, including defence, space, nuclear energy, technology and innovation.

The leaders positively noted the announcement by the UAE’s International Holding Company to invest \$11.5 b in the development of an integrated greenfield aluminium project in Odisha, according to an official readout. The two leaders reiterated the significance of the India-UAE Comprehensive Strategic Partnership and recalled the recent successful visits by UAE President Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan to India



PM with UAE Crown Prince Al Nahyan



PM with Anwar Ibrahim

in January 2026 and that of Prime Minister Modi to the UAE in May 2026.

Separately, Modi held a bilateral meeting with Anwar bin Ibrahim, Prime Minister of Malaysia, on the sidelines of the 18th BRICS Summit and took stock of the outcomes of Modi’s visit to Malaysia in February 2026. They reviewed progress in bilateral cooperation across a range of areas, including trade and investment, defence and security, semiconductors, infrastructure, digital economy, energy, fintech, education, tourism and people-to-people ties. Malaysia is among the BRICS partner countries.

Ibrahim conveyed Malaysia’s concurrence to the establishment of the Consulate General of India in Kota Kinabalu, Sabah.

“Our discussion focused on efforts to expand cooperation in strategic sectors, particularly the semiconductor industry. Malaysia and India possess complementary strengths that can be harnessed through industrial collaboration, supply chain integration, talent development, and two-way investments. I also raised the need to facilitate and accelerate the entry of Malaysian export goods into the Indian market to open up greater opportunities for Malaysian companies to tap into India’s vast and rapidly growing market potential,” Ibrahim tweeted following his meeting with Modi.

It may be pointed out that India and Malaysia are establishing a multi-layered arrangement to collaborate in the semiconductor sector.

‘SEVA SANKALP ABHIYAN’

UP BJP Gears Up for Month-Long Grassroots Outreach

‘Seva Setu’ camps to help eligible people enrol in govt schemes

Sanjay Singh

New Delhi: The BJP’s Uttar Pradesh unit is set to use the month-long ‘Seva Sankalp Abhiyan’, beginning on Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s birthday on September 17, to step up its grassroots outreach ahead of next year’s assembly elections through yatras, cleanliness drives and government scheme enrolment camps.

Chief minister Yogi Adityanath on Saturday shared the blueprint of the campaign at a joint press conference with the party’s UP president Pankaj Choudhary in Lucknow.

The coordinated campaign between the party and the government will showcase the achievements of the central government over the past 12 years, as well as those of the state government over the last decade at all levels from gram panchayats and development blocks to tehsils and districts for a month.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s journey from his birthplace Vadnagar to his current constituency Varanasi is incorporated in the campaign, Adityanath told reporters.

Ten yatras each will be organised from Vadnagar to Kashi and from Kashi to Vadnagar. Those travelling to Vadnagar will carry holy water from 10 rivers of UP. “Chaupals and public interaction programmes will be held at four locations along the yatra route each day,” he said.

All yatras will begin on September 17 and reach their respective destination on October 7 when Modi will complete 25 years as the head of a government – first as the chief



minister of Gujarat and later as the prime minister.

A key component of the campaign will be ‘Seva Setu’ camps, which will be organised in each development block and municipal body across the state between September 29 and October 10, where people eligible for different government schemes, including pensions, health schemes, housing, toilets and ration cards, can register for those schemes. The government plans to complete the formalities and ensure linking such eligible persons with the schemes at the camp itself within 2-3 days of registration.

Modi’s birthday will be celebrated as ‘Seva Diwas’. An ‘Ashirvad Ka Diya’ will be lit at village panchayats, municipal bodies and other establishments across the state for people to “pray for the healthy and long life of the prime minister,” Adityanath said.

QUESTIONS 100% TAP COVERAGE CLAIM

CAG Flags Data Inconsistencies in Gujarat’s Jal Jeevan Mission

DP Bhattacharya

Gandhinagar: The implementation of the Jal Jeevan Mission in Gujarat was marked by data discrepancies and reporting flaws, according to a Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) report for the year ended March 2024.

The report said the e-Jalshakti portal and the State Annual Action Plan (SAAP) had declared 100% functional household tap connection (FHTC) coverage across 9.12 million rural households by October 2022. However, an audit of District Annual Action Plans (DAAPs) across 27 districts found that 1.48 million households were still pending FHTC coverage as of April 1, 2024.

“According to the e-Jalshakti portal and SAAP, the state had declared 100% FHTC coverage totaling 91.18 lakh households by October 2022. Contrarily, DAAPs from 27 districts still reflected 14.84 lakh households pending FHTC coverage as of April 1, 2024,” the CAG report said.

PARTY LEADERSHIP DENIES MERGER PLAN

Eight UDP MLAs in Talks With BJP, Says Party Legislator

Bikash Singh

Guwahati: United Democratic Party (UDP) MLA Ollan Singh Suin said eight legislators from his party were in discussions with the BJP and that “anything can happen any time, any day”.

His comment came amid speculation that this group of MLAs is planning to merge with the BJP. Meanwhile, UDP general secretary Titosstarwell Chyne said there was no question of anyone leaving the party.

The UDP has 12 MLAs in the 60-member Meghalaya assembly, while the BJP has two. Both parties are part of the ruling alliance led by the National People’s Party (NPP). Former UDP MLA Jemino Mawthoh joined the BJP on Saturday.

Suin, who represents Mawsynram in the assembly, said on Friday that the group of legislators in touch with the BJP had made certain demands. “We will see once they agree to our demands,” he said, adding: “If the union government agrees to our demands, what is the problem.”

INDEFINITE HUNGER STRIKE TOO

Jarange Patil Announces Mumbai March From Sept 15



Mumbai: Maratha leader Manoj Jarange Patil on Saturday announced a march to Mumbai from September 15, where he would hold an indefinite hunger strike at Azad Maidan to demand OBC reservation for the Maratha community. Patil exhorted his followers to march to the country’s financial capital in large numbers, calling it the “last battle” for the community’s demand, and warned the Maharashtra government against trying to stop them. –OPB

Statement Kumar Anshuman

PM SHRI Rollout, IUML Opposition Test Kerala CM

The implementation of the PM SHRI scheme in Kerala has become a major challenge for Chief Minister VD Satheesan. In June, Satheesan decided to implement the central government’s PM SHRI school scheme, but could not do so because of objections from key ally IUML. Kerala Education Minister N Samsudheen is from the IUML.

The scheme was not implemented during the LDF rule. To avoid confrontation, the state government formed a cabinet sub-committee to decide on the matter. The committee includes ministers from the government, including Samsudheen, but is yet to meet to discuss the implementation.

Meanwhile, the state government has received two letters from the Union Education Ministry, the second this week. In its letter, the central government has clearly asked the state government to decide on the implementation of the scheme. The BJP is now demanding that the state government go ahead with the implementation, saying students of the state should not suffer because of the government’s decision.

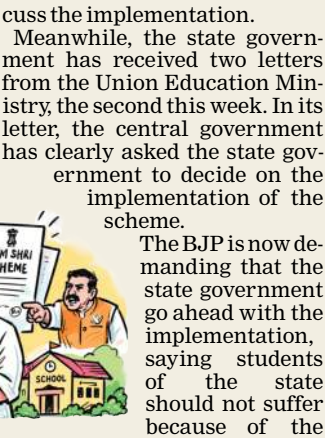
Satheesan is now busy talking to allies to convince them. He is also speaking to ministers of Congress-ruled states to find out how the scheme was implemented in their states.

Congress and the BJP are battling it out from Uttarakhand to Delhi over an incident in which some people purportedly purified a stage used by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge in Haldwani. Now, Congress is alleging a similar incident in Telangana, this time involving BRS workers.

Last Monday, BRS legislators tried to enter the Assembly session wearing black T-shirts to protest against 1,000 days of the Congress government in the state. When state police tried to stop them, a scuffle broke out. Congress leaders accused BRS MLA Tata Madhu of making filthy and derogatory remarks against Speaker G Prasad Kumar. Kumar belongs to the Dalit community, and Congress leaders strongly objected to the remarks.

The next day, Congress workers took out a march to former CM and BRS leader KCR’s farmhouse to protest the remarks made by Madhu.

On Wednesday, some BRS workers sprinkled turmeric water on the road near the farmhouse, which Congress called a purification exercise by the BRS and accused the party of having an anti-Dalit mindset.



FOOD CHOICE ROW Bengal CM Adhikari Joins ‘Mach Bhog’ at Kalighat Temple



West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari was seen having ‘Mach Bhog’ at Kalighat temple in Kolkata, sending a direct message to the people of the state that the government and the BJP have no intention of banning non-veg food near pandals during Durga Puja.

Last week, Adhikari offered a grand welcome to Dharendra Shastri, known as ‘Bageshwar Dham Baba’, who was in the state to hold his religious programmes. At one such programme in Howrah, Shastri appealed to people of the state to avoid consuming non-veg food near puja pandals during Navaratri.

His appeal met with resistance from opposition parties, including Congress. Congress workers held protests in different parts of the state, where they also tried to burn the effigy of Dharendra Shastri. Chief Minister Adhikari, during the Assembly session, strongly criticised those protesting against Shastri and even called for their arrests.

However, as the protest and dissent over freedom of food choices grew in the state, Adhikari was on the back foot. Several BJP leaders, including state BJP president Samik Bhattacharya, went on to say that food choices are purely a matter for the people of West Bengal and that no outsider can give them instructions on what to eat and what not to.



HARSH V SHRINGLA

At the 18th BRICS Summit, India is doing more than hosting another diplomatic event. The summit falls in the twentieth year of BRICS cooperation and during India’s fourth chairmanship. BRICS has 11 members and represents close to half the world’s population.

For India, the value of BRICS has never rested on turning it into another rigid bloc. Our foreign policy is strongest when it enlarges our room for manoeuvre. Strategic autonomy means freedom to work with different partners on different issues. BRICS gives India an additional platform to advance a more representative global order, while continuing to build strong partnerships elsewhere. The expanded grouping requires ambition and realism. Its members do not share identical political systems or foreign-policy priorities; consensus will sometimes be difficult. India’s

BRICS: Strategic Autonomy at Work for the People

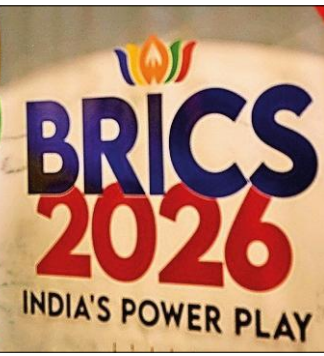
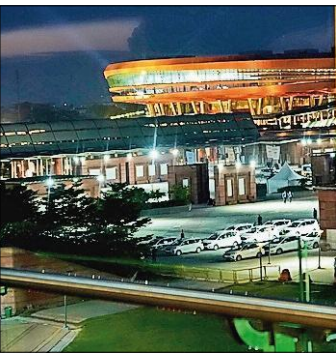
For India, BRICS is not about creating another rigid bloc. Its value lies in expanding India’s strategic room for manoeuvre

contribution should be to keep BRICS focused on areas where cooperation is possible: development, technology, health, food and energy security, counter-terrorism and reform of global governance. The aim should be practical multipolarity, not bloc politics. BRICS as a means of strengthening multipolarity without compromising India’s other partnerships is identified as one of the grouping’s principal utilities for Delhi.

India’s 2026 chairship has tried to give this approach a human face. At the Rio Summit last year, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said India would take BRICS forward with a “people-centric approach” and in the spirit of “Humanity First”. That idea runs through the chairship theme of Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability. More than 350 meetings have been concluded as part of a programme of over 400 engagements, spread across nearly 30 Indian cities. The political test is whether these mechanisms improve citizens’ lives. Consider agriculture. The BRICS

Network on Digital Agriculture and Centres of Excellence on Agro-Ecology and Regenerative Agriculture can help share technology and climate-resilient practices. The real test is whether this knowledge travels through our agricultural universities and state governments to improve crop choices and reduce risk. The same test applies to health and employment. There is promise for India’s star-

tups. The action plan on innovation-led growth by startups provides for a BRICS Incubator Network connecting nodal agencies, incubators and firms across member countries, including referrals of qualified startups to incubators in other BRICS economies. It recommends a BRICS Startup Innovation Fund, with voluntary public and private financing, for early- and growth-stage ventures. During Brazil’s 2025 chairship, the



BRICS Women’s Startups Contest was designed to connect women-led ventures with investors, accelerators and innovation ecosystems. India should now make that logic more durable than episodic. The proposed “Bharat Innovates” platform can add momentum by showcasing India’s startup and innovation ecosystem to the BRICS network.

The BRICS MSME Cooperation Portal, Dialogue on Finance and Workplan on the Internationalisation of MSMEs are intended to improve access to finance, technology and markets. India should use these mechanisms to widen opportunities by reducing procedural friction, improving standards cooperation and helping smaller firms participate in value chains across broader markets. India’s chairship produced principles on community-based adaptation, climate-resilient urban infrastructure, smart grids and energy storage. The New Development Bank’s 2022-26 strategy set a target of directing 40% of financing to climate miti-

gation and adaptation. A useful step would be to connect BRICS climate principles more systematically with finance, perhaps through a climate-resilience window or guarantee facility within NDI. The BRICS Leaders’ Framework Declaration on Climate Finance adopted in Rio provides political grounding, while the BRICS Multilateral Guarantees initiative is being incubated as a pilot within NDB to de-risk infrastructure and sustainable-development investment. A focused climate window could turn those principles into investible projects.

NDB shows how multilateral institutions become politically relevant when they produce visible assets. As of June 2026, India was its second-largest recipient, with 35 approved projects worth \$10.5 b and roughly \$6 billion disbursed. The portfolio includes transport, water, clean energy and urban infrastructure.

Regarding security, terrorism, cybercrime, illicit drugs, disruptions in food and energy supplies and fragile

supply chains affect the safety of families, cost of living and local economies. Prime Minister Modi has argued within BRICS for an unequivocal approach to terrorism and against double standards. Cooperation matters when it improves information sharing, institutional capacity and preparedness.

The credibility of India’s chairship should be judged a year later: Are incubator links functioning? Are startups securing cross-border pilots or investment? Are MSMEs using the platforms? Are farmers and researchers participating? Are climate and infrastructure projects moving from approval to completion? Several mechanisms remain voluntary or developmental; implementation will determine their real value.

BRICS can strengthen India’s strategic autonomy and amplify the voice of the Global South. But its lasting legitimacy will come from something more immediate: whether international cooperation creates greater security and opportunity for ordinary people. India should seek a BRICS that is ambitious abroad, practical in its institutions and accountable at home.

The writer is a Rajya Sabha MP

TWO LEADERS SEEK TO STABILISE TIES, ADDRESS TRADE IMBALANCES AND SUPPLY CHAIN ISSUES

Peace, Tranquillity on Border
Need of the Hour: Modi to Xi

Dipanjn Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: India and China on Saturday sought to further stabilise their ties, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi during his meeting with President Xi Jinping emphasising that peace and tranquillity in the border areas were essential for continued development of bilateral relations.

The two leaders expressed commitment to a fair, reasonable and mutually acceptable resolution of the boundary question, proceeding from the political perspective of their overall bilateral relations and the long-term interests of the two peoples.

Xi is in India for the first time in seven years to attend the BRICS Summit. At their meeting held on the margins of the summit, Modi underlined the need for both sides to observe existing agreements and understandings on border-related issues.

India and China signed a series of agreements in the 1990s and 2000s to keep the Life of Actual Control (LAC) stable and peaceful. New Delhi has repeatedly stated that the border affairs would reflect on the state of bilateral ties.

The two leaders welcomed steady progress in India-China bilateral relations since their last meeting in Tianjin, China, in August 2025.



Chinese President Xi Jinping & PM Narendra Modi in New Delhi on Saturday

They reaffirmed that both countries should take a strategic and long-term perspective of their ties and that differences should not become disputes. The Prime Minister highlighted that both sides be guided by three mutuals: mutual respect, mutual sensitivity and mutual interest.

Xi told Modi that India and China must work together for the future of mankind.

The two leaders took note of the progress in people-to-people ties and underscored the need to further promote cultural exchanges, business linkages and greater mobility between the two countries.

On economic and trade relations, they underlined the need to address each other's concerns, including structural trade imbalance and supply chain issues, and facilitation of meaningful and predictable market access.

India is seeking wider market access in China to reduce trade imbalance and stated that Beijing should not weaponise supply chains.

Last month, ET reported that India and China were exploring a new framework to facilitate business-to-business exchanges and Chinese investments, with a focus on accelerated capital flow.

The leaders agreed that both sides must continue to expand common ground on regional and global issues, and in addressing challenges, according to a foreign ministry readout.

The Prime Minister in particular appreciated China's support for India's BRICS chairship and contributions towards the success of the BRICS Summit-2026.

Ties have started stabilising since Modi and Xi met in Kazan on the sidelines of the BRICS Summit in 2024 followed by their meeting in Tianjin on the margins of the SCO Summit in 2025. However, progress to improve overall health of ties has been slow while being steady. The Line of Actual Control has been largely incident free over the past year.

Ahead of Xi's visit, India and China last month reached an eight-point understanding including creation of additional two meeting points for holding the General Level Mechanism/ Senior Highest Military Commander meeting (SHMC) and two additional channels of border military hotline in the Eastern and Middle Sectors with the objective to improve the border management measures with the goal of stabilising the LAC.

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BRICS Hits Out at Unilateral Tariffs, CBAMs

Our Bureau

New Delhi: BRICS leaders on Saturday opposed "unilateral tariff and non-tariff measures" such as carbon border adjustment mechanisms (CBAMs), saying such steps undermine developing countries' efforts to address climate change and calling "for the elimination of such unlawful measures".

"We condemn the imposition of unilateral coercive measures that are contrary to international law, and reiterate that such measures, inter alia in the form of unilateral economic sanctions and secondary sanctions, have far-reaching negative implications for the human rights," the leaders said in the New Delhi Declaration adopted after the summit.

The bloc proposed exploring pragmatic solutions for efficient cross-border payment mechanisms and studying the interoperability of payment and messaging channels across borders. It also called for discussions on promoting trade settlements and investments using BRICS local currencies, while respecting national priorities and acknowledging that there is no one-size-fits-all approach.

Sudhakar Dalela, secretary — economic relations at the ministry of external affairs, said the discussion on trade in local currency has been going on for over a decade. "There is no proposal in the BRICS for a BRICS currency as of now," he said.

The declaration called for more resilient supply chains and greater participation by developing

countries in higher-value manufacturing through investment, technology transfer and productive-capacity building.

A BRICS Global Value Chain Action Plan for 2026-30 is intended to help emerging economies move up the production ladder, while cooperation on special economic zones and digital trade documentation is aimed at reducing friction for businesses.



The bloc warned that trade-restrictive measures could "further reduce global trade, disrupt global supply chains and introduce uncertainty into international economic and trade activities".

Condemning unilateral, punitive, discriminatory and coercive measures that are contrary to international law, the leaders encouraged continued discussions to find practical solutions for cross-border payments among BRICS countries. They also called for sweeping reform of the global financial architecture to give emerging markets and developing economies a greater voice in the International Monetary Fund and the World Bank.

The grouping said quota realignment under the multilateral institutions should reflect countries' relative positions in the global economy and increase the quota and voting shares of emerging markets and developing countries, without coming at the expense of developing countries.

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111,525 SQ FT SPACE

Booking.com
Leases Office
Space in
Bengaluru

Kaillash Babar

Mumbai: Booking.com has leased 111,525 sq ft of office space at RMZ Ecoworld in Bengaluru for five years, expanding its footprint in India.

The company's Indian subsidiary, Booking Holdings India, has leased the space directly from developer RMZ Hotels through a fresh lease agreement.

The lease commenced on July 3 and covers the eighth floor of RMZ Ecoworld Series 30, Campus 30, according to registration documents accessed through real estate data analytics platform Propstack.

Booking Holdings India will pay monthly rent of ₹1.33 crore, translating into a rental rate of ₹119.6 per sq ft. The lease carries a security deposit of ₹8 crore. The agreement provides for a 15% escalation in rent every three years.

With the latest transaction, Booking Holdings' total office footprint in the commercial tower has increased to about 265,000 sq ft, according to property data.

Booking Holdings is also occupying the seventh and eighth floors at Campus 31 within RMZ Ecoworld, giving it a sizeable presence across the development.

With an Eye on Profit
Zomato Levies 2%
Fee on COD Orders

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Food delivery platform Zomato has started levying 2% of the cart value, capped at ₹30, as fee for cash-on-delivery orders, according to information on its mobile application.

"This pay-on-delivery fee is a convenience charge for customers who choose to pay at their doorstep," an executive said, requesting not to be named. "These transactions involve additional operational processes and require significantly more coordination to facilitate cash or QR-based payments at the time of delivery."

The pay-on-delivery fee is in addition to the various other charges that food delivery customers pay, including a platform fee, which is currently ₹14.99 per order before taxes.

The executive cited earlier said cash-on-delivery orders account for about 20% of Zomato's total orders. According to sources, the platform received 270-280 million food delivery orders in the June quarter.

Zomato did not respond to ET's request for a comment.

Swiggy, its competitor, has not yet implemented a similar levy.

The pay-on-delivery fee is expected to add to Zomato's profitability. The company reported adjusted earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortisation (Ebitda) of ₹606 crore in the first quarter of FY27, up 34% year-on-year. Its net order value (NOV) stood

Busy Season

Zomato received
270-280
MILLION
food delivery
orders in the
June quarter



at ₹10,769 crore, up 20% year-on-year.

Meanwhile, the latest entrant in the space, Ownly, has started with a promise of not charging a fee for cash-on-delivery orders. The food delivery platform, run by mobility company Rapido, only charges users a delivery fee. Unlike its competitors, it also does not charge commissions to restaurant partners. Swiggy has started "Toing" to compete with Ownly, which is currently operational in Bengaluru and plans to add more cities to its network.

In its June-quarter shareholders' letter, Zomato founder Deepinder Goyal said the company saw limited impact on its business from Ownly and Toing. "These platforms are offering the same restaurants, similar or longer delivery times, and lower menu prices funded by lower commissions and delivery fee — making the revenue gap even more unsustainable," Goyal wrote.

Lagarde Wades into French Poll Politics

ECB chief dismisses far left opponent's idea to wipe out debt as 'financially dangerous'

Bloomberg

Christine Lagarde entered France's presidential-election fray at a political gathering on Saturday, as speculation builds that she'll leave the European Central Bank early.

Her speech in rural Normandy transported her far from the technicalities of setting interest rates, just days after she and her ECB colleagues delivered a second hike to contain inflation spurred by the Iran war.

"Here at the Fête de la Pomme, we celebrate something distinctly Norman," Lagarde said. "Europe has helped that regional identity become a greater source of prosperity, opening markets while protecting what makes local products distinctive."

The annual event, hosted by the region's president, Hervé Morin, has more to do with politics than apples. Past editions have featured conservative presidential hopefuls, including Bruno Retailleau, who wants to feature in next year's ballot.

While Lagarde has described being France's president as a "terrible job," she also said recently that she wants to make



2027, and news that her memoir, *Lady First*, will arrive in late January has added to chatter that she's ready to open a new chapter away from Frankfurt, with the World Economic Forum considered a likely destination.

With less than eight months until the first round of voting, France's election campaign is hotting up. While outgoing President Emmanuel Macron has embraced and defended the European Union, the frontrunners in the race to replace him have sketched out policies that challenge its rules and institutions.

Polls currently show far-right leader Marine Le Pen, who wants to cut EU funding, has a strong lead. Some surveys point to the far left's Jean-Luc Mélenchon as her opponent in a runoff on May 2.

Mélenchon has set the tone of the debate so far with calls to tackle France's rising debt mountain by canceling bonds held at the ECB and the Bank of France. He's also slammed the ECB's rate hikes, saying they're driving the economy into a wall. Lagarde voiced her opinion on wiping out debt on Thursday, calling any such move legally impossible and "financially dangerous."

Washington Slaps 123% Anti-dumping
Duty on Indian Solar Cells, Panels

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The US on Friday finalised duties on imports of solar cells and panels from India, Indonesia and Laos following two sets of investigations. It set an anti-dumping margin of 123.04% on Mundra Solar PV, Mundra Solar Energy, Kowa Company and Premier Energies Photovoltaic Private Ltd and a countervailing duty of 126.09% on Mundra Solar Energy, Mundra Solar PV and others.

The US Commerce Department also assigned an anti-dumping margin of 94.36% to producers from Indonesia and 65.43% to those from Laos. It set countervailing duty rates of 73.2% to 173.7% for In-

donesian producers and 82.03% to 153.67% for producers from Laos. The investigations covered crystalline silicon photovoltaic cells, whether or not assembled into modules, from the three countries.

The US International Trade Commission is likely to make a final determination next month on whether the imports materially injured or threatened to injure American manufacturers.

"The International Trade Commission (ITC) is running concurrent injury determination investigations," the US Department of Commerce said in a statement.

The development comes as India and the US negotiate a Bilateral

Trade Agreement (BTA), the first tranche of which would come into force as soon as Washington ensures that India secured a comparative advantage over its competitors.

The US imposed a 10% tariff on India under a Section 301 probe on forced labour and is also in the process of enacting legislation that could see tariffs of up to 100% imposed on India and four other countries for being the top importers of Russian oil and gas.

Washington has also named India among 41 countries as being part of a "shadow trans-shipment network" that allegedly allows Chinese goods to bypass American tariffs and announced plans to deploy AI to identify and crack down on such shipments.



ANTHROPIC SEEKS TO RAISE \$100 B THAT COULD VALUE CO AT AROUND \$2 TRILLION

Nvidia In Talks with Anthropic
to Invest in World's Largest IPO

Reuters

Anthropic is in talks to bring Nvidia as an anchor investor into what could be the largest IPO in history, two people familiar with the matter told Reuters.

Anthropic is seeking to raise as much as \$100 billion that could value the artificial intelligence startup at around \$2 trillion, the people said. Nvidia is considering investing up to \$10 billion in the IPO, one of the sources added. The plans remain under discussion and could change, they cautioned, requesting anonymity because the discussions are confidential.

Nvidia's potential involvement in the IPO, which has not previously been reported, would give Anthropic an early strategic backer for the outsized offering, while further deepening ties between the chipmaker and one of its major customers. Bringing a deep-pocketed anchor investor like Nvidia onboard could boost investor confidence in the listing, which is shaping up to be a major test of public-market appetite for the enormous valuations and capital requirements of frontier AI labs.

Anthropic declined to comment. Nvidia did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

Anchor investors are typically in-



stitutional investors that commit to buy a set portion of an IPO before it is marketed more broadly, providing an early vote of confidence in the shares. It is increasingly common for mega IPOs to line up early institutional commitments, given the large amounts they seek to raise.

Chip designer Arm's anchor investors included Nvidia and Amazon, while Saudi Arabia's PIF was among SpaceX's anchor investors.

The deepened relationship highlights the complex ties between AI model developers and the companies supplying the enormous amounts of computing power they require.

Anthropic relies heavily on Nvidia GPUs, while also seeking to diversify its chip suppliers as demand for Claude has strained its available computing capacity.

In November 2025, Nvidia said it would invest up to \$10 billion in the AI startup as part of a broader partnership under which Anthropic committed to buy \$30 billion of Microsoft Azure computing capacity powered by Nvidia chips.

Anthropic already counts the biggest tech companies in the world as backers. These include Amazon and Google, who are also its major compute suppliers.

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SCAN TO APPLY

A TIMES INTERNET INITIATIVE



Shantanu Nandan Sharma | Sukma (Chhattisgarh)

At her mud-walled, low-roofed home in the village of Puwarti in Sukma, Chhattisgarh, Madvi Hunge is busy winnowing rice. She is willing to talk, but not before making a sarcastic complaint: “Till Hidma died, no one came to meet us.”

Madvi Hidma, one of Bastar’s most feared Maoists, was the brother-in-law of Hunge. He headed a dreaded battalion of CPI (Maoist) until he and his wife, Rajakka, were killed in neighbouring Andhra Pradesh last year.

Among Hunge’s guests that day is a young headman, or Patel, of a nearby village. Until last year, he had to pay ₹15,000 to the Maoist party as shulk, or fee, for owning a tractor.

“This is the first year no one is paying a ‘tax’, not even the ‘sangam shulk’ of ₹350 per villager,” says the Patel, requesting anonymity. Sangam is a village-level administrative unit of CPI (Maoist). “Though I am a village headman, I had no option but to follow the party’s diktat. Tables have turned now. When Maoist leaders return to villages, they will have to follow the orders of the Patel and other village elders,” he adds.

This fraught reversal of power is a reason why more than 1,000 former Maoists continue to be housed in rehabilitation centres set up in district headquarters across Bastar region, even though the government declared the end of armed Maoism on March 31, 2026—a deadline it had set for itself two years earlier.

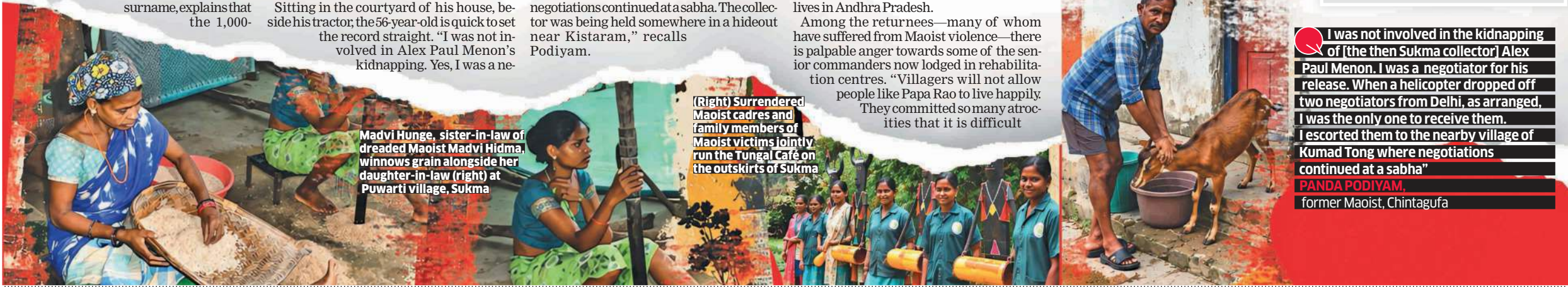
The Bastar division comprises seven districts of Chhattisgarh—Bastar, Bijapur, Dantewada, Kondagaon, Kanker, Narayanpur and Sukma.

NOT A CAKEWALK

Recently, videos of some former Maoists from Bastar walking a ramp in Raipur went viral, suggesting a return to peace. However, rehabilitating former armed cadres, many of whom were highly indoctrinated, is hardly a cakewalk. The state is treading cautiously, keeping former hardcore Maoists in rehab centres in an effort to shield them from a possible backlash from villagers and to prevent renewed radicalisation.

“About 1,800 surrendered Maoists have already returned to their villages across Bastar. Except for a couple of instances in Bijapur district where there were some scuffles with villagers, former Maoists have integrated reasonably well into village life,” says Vivekanand, additional director general of police in charge of anti-Naxal operations in Chhattisgarh. “Some of the highly indoctrinated, hardcore Maoists may take time to shed the sense of authority associated with their earlier leadership roles and adjust to a social order traditionally guided by elders such as Patels, gaitas (traditional healers) and pujaris (priests).”

The officer, who does not use a surname, explains that the 1,000-



“The world is everything, that is the case,” Ludwig Wittgenstein wrote in *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, 1921. A century later, artificial intelligence may finally be taking him on his word.

Earlier this month, World Labs, founded by AI pioneer Fei-Fei Li, released something called Atlas. An almost magical demo of that went viral: give Atlas a single photograph, then move a virtual camera around it, and you can look at the scene from the side, above it, behind it, even at parts the original camera never saw.

From one flat image, Atlas imagines a coherent three-dimensional world around it. Give it a few more images and imagination transforms to reconstruction. World Labs calls Atlas an “omni world model”, trained natively across text, images, video and 3D.

Since ChatGPT burst onto our world four years ago, AI has been synonymous with LLMs, or large language models. Every month since then has brought us more and more powerful LLMs, trained on trillions of parameters, costing billions of dollars. But just making LLMs more powerful is not the next frontier; the next inflection could be world models.

This is because the world is not a paragraph of words but exists in a glorious three-dimensional cornucopia of objects, sounds, sights and senses.

Return of Old Reds

The homecoming of over 3,000 former Maoists is no easy task in Bastar. The state is treading cautiously, keeping over 1,000 in rehabilitation centres—to shield them from possible wrath of villagers and to prevent renewed radicalisation

plus cadres in rehabilitation centres are being categorised into different groups, with recent recruits separated from highly radicalised members. “There has been considerable emphasis on their social reintegration and mental preparedness for a new innings. Yoga classes are one of the modules designed to help in that transition,” he says.

To reach Puwarti, ET travelled on a newly paved, 58 km blacktop road from Dornapal to Jagargunda in Sukma, cutting across villages that once witnessed some of Bastar’s bloodiest gunfights.

“It was for the construction of this very road that more than 300 jawans were martyred,” says Amit Kumar, district magistrate of Sukma. Multiple memorials have come up along the route, he adds, as tributes to those who lost their lives. At Tadmetla, for instance, the names of 76 security personnel—mostly from CRPF—who were killed in a devastating Maoist attack in 2010 are etched on marble slabs at the foot of a hillock.

WHEN A COLLECTOR WAS KIDNAPPED

On the way, at Chintagufa, villagers escort this writer to the home of Panda Podiyam, known locally as one of the “most influential former Maoists”. He is often linked to the sensational kidnapping of Alex Paul Menon, who was the collector of Sukma, in 2012—a case that made international headlines.

Sitting in the courtyard of his house, beside his tractor, the 56-year-old is quick to set the record straight. “I was not involved in Alex Paul Menon’s kidnapping. Yes, I was a ne-

About 1,800 surrendered Maoists have returned to their villages across Bastar. Except for some scuffles with villagers in Bijapur, they have integrated reasonably well into village life. Some hardcore Maoists may take time to shed the authority associated with their earlier roles and adjust to a social order traditionally guided by elders”

VIVEKANAND, Additional DGP, in-charge of anti-Naxal operations, Chhattisgarh

gotiator for his release,” he says.

Podiyam recalls that he telephoned bureaucrats in Delhi and elsewhere at the direction of Ravula Srinivas, better known as Ramanna, who headed the Maoists’ Dandakaranya region until his death in 2019.

“When a helicopter dropped off two negotiators from Delhi, as arranged, there was no one but me to receive them. I then escorted them to the nearby village of Kumad Tong, where negotiations continued at a sabha. The collector was being held somewhere in a hideout near Kistaram,” recalls Podiyam.

Menon was released after 12 days in captivity.

About 150-200 members of Hidma’s armed battalion of the People’s Liberation Guerrilla Army (PLGA) would once gather in the very courtyard where we are now sitting. “The police outpost, barely 100 metres away, could do nothing to prevent such a gathering,” says Podiyam, who surrendered in 2017.

Several villagers offer a telling description of life in those days. There were two nakas or checkpoints—one manned by the security personnel, the other by the Maoists.

LONG SHADOW OF PAST

At Jagargunda, which once hosted a bustling tamarind mandi and drew prosperous traders from Andhra Pradesh, a remnant of the past lies by the roadside, half-sunk in muddy, marshy ground—a large tijori (safe).

Until the 1990s—before the Maoists tightened their grip over the region—it was not unusual for wealthy traders and mahua liquor distillers to own such safes. “This tijori belonged to my stepfather,” says S Nageshwar Rao, 70.

Rao is among the scores of villagers who have recently returned to Jagargunda to reclaim their homes, land and other belongings. When the village emerged as a Maoist stronghold in the mid-2000s, traders, government employees and others fled. Some, like Rao, crossed the state border to begin new lives in Andhra Pradesh.

Among the returnees—many of whom have suffered from Maoist violence—there is palpable anger towards some of the senior commanders now lodged in rehabilitation centres. “Villagers will not allow people like Papa Rao to live happily. They committed so many atrocities that it is difficult

for the victims to forget or forgive,” says a Jagargunda resident, as several others around him nod in agreement.

Papa Rao, alias Mongu, was one of south Bastar’s feared Maoist leaders and a member of the Dandakaranya Special Zonal Committee (SZC). He surrendered in March this year, just days before the government’s deadline.

Podiyam, however, believes that the surrendered cadres, with a few exceptions, will be welcomed back to their villages, thanks to the goodwill they had earned through their work in the past.

Gaurav Kumar Singh, district magistrate of Raipur, says former Maoists have to win the trust of villagers for a quick return to normalcy in areas once considered highly sensitive.

Singh, who served as chief executive officer of the zilla panchayat in Dantewada between 2016 and 2018, recalls that several civil and police officers had made deliberate efforts to earn the confidence of local communities even at the height of insurgency.

“My wife and I decided that our daughter, Aadya, would be born in Dantewada in 2017. We also made it a point not to shop in Raipur or elsewhere, but to buy whatever we needed from the local markets of Dantewada,” he recalls.

While most surrendered cadres intend to return to their villages, there are exceptions—a few enterprising former Maoists are seeking economic opportunities in and around nearby towns.

Many have moved to a new life beyond guns.

Five female Maoists who surrendered in Konta, for instance, are running the beautiful Tungal Café, set amidst forest and water bodies on the outskirts of Sukma town.

“Surrendered cadres and family members of Maoist victims are working together and happily running the Tungal Café,” says District Magistrate Kumar, describing the initiative as a possible template for Bastar’s social integration in the years ahead.

Nine female cadres from Sukma, who went viral when they took part in a fashion show in Raipur in August, are now being trained to weave handloom silk products.

“Several surrendered Maoists who were earlier associated with the party’s cultural wing, Chetna Natya Manch, are being roped into stage street plays in villages, spreading awareness about government schemes and initiatives,” says Kumar.

The administration is also looking to reinvent Sukma’s image. “We are planning to introduce river rafting in a 7 km stretch of the Sabari river near Errabore, hoping to attract tourists from cities such as Vijayawada and Hyderabad,” he says. Sukma, he believes, could well emerge as a tourism hotspot in the

BEYOND GUNS

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years to come.

The prospect marks a striking turn for Errabore. Twenty years ago, in 2006, the village made grim national headlines, when Maoists launched a brutal attack on a Salwa Judum camp, killing 31 people. For the police, the hunt is still on for Muppala Lakshmana Rao alias Ganapathi, a politburo member and former general secretary; his wife Alluri Krishnakumari alias Sujatha, an SZC member; their bodyguard Mantu and his Odia wife.

“It is a group of four—three Telugu speakers and an Odia,” says a police officer, requesting anonymity. “But it is unlikely that they are anywhere in Chhattisgarh.”

GANAPATHI & GOSWAMI

When the police looked for clues to track down the 76-year-old Ganapathi, they stumbled on a new lead—the presence of a “mysterious” Assamese Maoist, Rituparna Goswami, in Bastar at least till 2019. A PhD scholar from JNU, Goswami, 47, is from Karbi Anglong and is believed to have been one of Ganapathi’s closest associates.

“When we showed Rituparna’s photograph to some surrendered Maoists from Bastar,

Surrendered cadres and family members of Maoist victims are working together and happily running the Tungal Café in Sukma. It could be a template for Bastar’s social integration in the years ahead”

AMIT KUMAR, District Magistrate, Sukma

one of them immediately recognised him, ‘Oh! He is Anil,’ recalls the police officer. The officer says Rituparna had been moving around Bastar until the pandemic began, using aliases like Anil and Naveen.

For the police, it has opened up yet another trail in their unfinished search for Ganapathi—and raised an intriguing question: where is Anil, or Naveen, after vanishing from Bastar?

shantanu.sharma@timesofindia.com

THE MORNING BRIEF PODCAST

The Bastar After The Gun

Surrendered Maoist cadres return to villages torn between forgiveness and lingering anger

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I was not involved in the kidnapping of (the then Sukma collector) Alex Paul Menon. I was a negotiator for his release. When a helicopter dropped off two negotiators from Delhi, as arranged, I was the only one to receive them. I escorted them to the nearby village of Kumad Tong where negotiations continued at a sabha”

PANDA PODIYAM, former Maoist, Chintagufa

The Next Great Leap

AI first learnt the words. Now it is reaching for the world

MORE THAN WORDS

LLMs have acquired extraordinary capabilities by consuming enormous quantities of text, images and increasingly other media. But humans do not learn this way. A child does not read Wikipedia before understanding that a cup falls when pushed off a table, or that a ball rolling behind a sofa still exists. AI’s “pre-training data” is the textual and visual internet, but our pre-training dataset is reality itself.

We see in three dimensions, we hear voices with tone and direction, we touch things, move through rooms, taste food and learn what happens when we act upon the physical world. Our developing brains continuously combine perception, movement, memory and prediction. Long before children acquire sophisticated language, they have absorbed an astonishing amount of common sense about objects, distance, gravity, other people, and cause and effect.

There is also a question of bandwidth. Typing communicates words, but speaking adds tone, rhythm, emphasis and sound, and that is why the best way to work with AI so far has been to speak with it. But vision adds infinitely more to it: objects, depth, movement and context, making the informational richness of an experience explode. Children do not need to be trained on the “entire internet”; they can learn remarkable things from comparatively little lived experience because each experience carries vastly more structure than a sentence.



PHYSICAL WORLD

This is precisely the limitation that Yann LeCun, one of AI’s foundational researchers, has been attacking for years. He argues that human-level intelligence cannot emerge simply by feeding machines ever more human-written text. Current systems, he says, are extremely good at manipulating language, which can fool us into “equating eloquence with intelligence”.

His alternative is AI that learns how the physical world works, predicts what will

happen after an action and uses that prediction to plan. Li has staked her next chapter on a related idea: spatial intelligence.

Her argument is that while language intelligence lets machines understand and generate words, spatial intelligence lets them reason about objects, places, geometry, movement and interactions in the physical world. She calls this the transition “from words to worlds”.

So, what exactly is a world model? At its simplest, it is an internal represen-

tation of an environment that allows AI to understand its state, imagine how it might change and predict the consequences of actions.

An LLM asks, loosely, “What token comes next?” A world model asks something closer to, “If this is the world now, and I do this, what will the world look like next?”

This shift might sound small, but its complexity and implications are enormous.

GAUSSIAN SPLAT

A wonderfully named building block in this new vocabulary is the Gaussian splat. A token is a small unit in a stream of language. A Gaussian splat is a tiny, fuzzy, semi-transparent blob positioned in 3D space.

Each carries information about where it sits, its shape, orientation, opacity and appearance. Millions of these splats can blend to form a photorealistic three-dimensional scene. “Gaussian” comes from Carl Friedrich Gauss and the bell-shaped mathematical distribution bearing his name.

“Splat” refers to how these fuzzy blobs are projected, or splatted, onto the screen to render the scene. Simplistically put, if tokens help machines talk about reality, splats help machines build and render it. Atlas can generate explicit 3D

World Labs founder Fei-Fei Li says spatial intelligence will let machines reason about objects, places, geometry, movement and interactions in the physical world



worlds as Gaussian splats, including geometry that no camera originally captured.

THE FUTURE

Now imagine where this can go.

A robot needs a world model to understand a kitchen rather than merely recognise the word “kitchen”. Autonomous vehicles need to predict how pedestrians and traffic will move. Factories could create living digital twins and test changes before touching the production line.

Architects could walk through buildings before constructing them. Students could enter ancient Rome rather than read a paragraph about it. Personal AI could understand where things are in our homes, not merely what our calendars say. At global scale, the same conceptual direction matters for weather, climate, materials, biology and other systems where intelligence means modelling complex worlds evolving over time.

If language can describe a cyclone, a world model aspires to simulate what the cyclone might do.

The obstacles to building world models are formidable, as physical causality is much harder than visual realism. World models will need far richer data, better representations of physics and vastly more grounding in reality. But the direction is important.

This leap can make machines that can understand where they are, what surrounds them, what might happen next and what their actions will change. As Li puts it, “Language gave machines a way to talk about that world. World models are how machines will finally come to understand, imagine, reason and interact with it.”

In the beginning was the Word. AI learnt that first. Now it is reaching for the World.

Views are personal

Nupur Amarnath

American poet Anne Sexton had one rule. “One of my secret instructions to myself as a poet is: Whatever you do, don’t be boring.” The poetry-verse on social media is following her brief, particularly in format. Poetry has learnt to travel beyond the book. A poem could find you as Khushi Thakur recites an obscure Hindi poem from Bulandshahr; as Aamir Azher introduces you to an Urdu sher from Bhopal; or as Olivia Dodd taps out one on a vintage typewriter from London. Meanwhile, Nidhi Narwal, Nayab Midha, Amandeep Singh and Yahya Bootwala, among others, deliver their viral verses straight to the camera. Priya Malik experienced the shift firsthand when her poem “2019 mein 1999” went viral in 2019. When it started landing on WhatsApp groups, Malik realised that something had changed: “For me, it was the real marker of mainstream reach. When a poem gets forwarded on WhatsApp, it enters people’s personal conversations and private worlds.” Seven years later, poetry is still travelling.

FINDING POEM

Earlier, encountering poetry required intent. You picked up a book, attended a mushaira or kavi sammelan, or studied it. Now, you get a one-minute ode tucked between a fashion reel and a meme. Midha, who has 3 million followers on Instagram, says what has changed is poetry’s visibility, accessibility and scale. “Today, discovery often happens in a 30-second reel or a clip. People who find a poem thus come to a live show, look for the longer piece, follow the poet’s work, or even start reading poetry,” she says. “Social media has essentially taken poetry from spaces people had to consciously enter and placed it in the middle of their everyday lives.” Singh, better known as Amandeep Khayal, says the socials have broadened poetry’s audience. “For earlier generations, the internet was introduced to them as ‘technology’. For Gen Z and Alpha, it is their playground.” A genuine poetry revival is underway, he says. “I too have discovered many ghazals and nazms on Instagram.”

Poetry gives words to emotions younger people find difficult to express, says Midha: “A lot of young people are experiencing complex emotions but don’t have the vocabulary to articulate. Poetry gives them that.”

Azher started Urdu Daan, an Instagram account and podcast, in 2020 to share his favourite shers. He realised that Urdu verses had a structural advantage in a short-form world. “A sher is just two lines, so it lends itself to a 10-second reel,” he says. “I see it as a gateway to a deeper engagement with poetry.”

Language is part of the appeal. For Singh, Hindi and Urdu carry nostalgia and homecoming.

He says: “Many of us communicate a lot in English now but we grew up speaking Hindi at home. So Hindi or Urdu becomes a refuge, home.”

Malik says it is about belonging. “For a long time, Indians were encouraged to see English as the language of success. What I’m seeing now is a correction. Hindi, Urdu and other Indian languages carry emotional textures that are deeply embedded in our cultural memory.”

Delhi-based librarian Renuka Verma stumbled across social-media poetry while scrolling Instagram. It has made her pay closer attention to language and pick up poetry books.

“I think good poetry creates curiosity. When a few lines touch you, you don’t want to stop at that post—you want to know who wrote them, what else they have written,” she says.

POETRY AS CONTENT

Poetry on reels comes with its own rules. Short-form platforms reward immediacy, relatability

Poetry has not just survived the age of social media but is thriving in it. As poem becomes reel, it moves beyond the literary space, turning poets into personalities and performances into content

Better for Verse

and visual appeal, while poetry demands time and attention. The first casualty is patience. Malik calls the opening words that can stop an audience mid-scroll the “gateway line”. “Attention spans are shorter, which means the first few lines often have to work harder,” she says. “Today’s audiences are also exposed to a huge volume of content every day, so they gravitate towards work that feels immediate, relatable and emotionally accessible.”

Mumbai-based storyteller and poet Yahya Bootwala has spent over a decade as a poet-performer, but finds the creator tag tougher. “You are creating content to cater to the audience.

When I started, it was to address my emotions, to perform my feelings. Now there is added pressure, because if you don’t post for six days, the reach goes down,” he says.

Then there are trending themes. Love, heart-break, loneliness, nostalgia, anxiety and even protest poems find an easy audience online. Short poetry was never Midha’s thing and most of her viral pieces are longer than what the algorithm supposedly favours. “Once you start performing, you learn what people respond to in your art. You begin to recognise what resonates and use those elements more. The downside is that it can take away from the magic of discovering something completely new,” she adds.

NAYAB MIDHA

@nayab.midha 3M followers “The big change is that poetry is no longer treated as a niche. Poetry isn’t becoming less literary, it is becoming more alive”



PRIYA MALIK @priyasometimes 736K followers “The appetite for poetry has always existed. The challenge was never the audience, it was creating platforms that met them where they already were”

The reel has also altered the poet’s job. Writing is now one part of a skill set that includes performance, videography, editing and maintaining a digital presence. A few years ago, Singh’s YouTube videos were shot with one or two cameras. Now, even a reel demands a more thought-out presentation. “We can modify the craft with the evolution of the art form, but the core essence should not be compromised,” he says.

Then there is the business of being a poet online. Brand collaborations can expect an entire emotional journey to fit neatly into 30-60 seconds. Midha says these days poets have to write, perform, create content, build a community and run a business. The good part? “Every artist can have their own set of fans; it cancels all the mediators, leaving no one between you and your audience,” she says. Singh finds the pressure to write regularly motivating. For Bootwala, the challenge is gathering an audience while remaining honest to the art.

That tension—between cre-

ating poetry and creating content—runs through the ecosystem. Malik believes social media should remain “a medium, not the destination”. But she values the communities it has created. “Virality may be fleeting, but the communities and cultural curiosity it creates can have a lasting impact on the art form.”

Kochi-based freelance journalist Fathima Abdul Kader, who has been consuming social-media poetry, believes the pervasive performativeness has made some poetry feel shallow. “Social media accessibil-

ity has created a space where people don’t really know what good poetry is. Just stringing together words without the required emotions or nuance behind it is not it.”

BEYOND THE FEED For Delhi-based English-language and soft-skills trainer Swati Rai, the shift has been in form: she engages with poetry more online than offline. She says, “Online poetry is a classic re-run and repackaging of the experience. It is a re-mounting of ageless poetry in the

grammar of the new world.” Similarly, Mumbai-based consultant paediatrician Dr Nandini Sarkar Shinde found her way back to poetry through social media. She follows the accounts of Rekhta Foundation, Kommune, Emily Dickinson Museum and international poetry collectives, among others. “Online poetry can be consumed on the go,” says Shinde, who now buys and gifts poetry books.

Verma says, “What I find interesting is that people, including me, don’t just follow poetry, we follow a poet. I like the sense of community that has developed around poetry online. People recommend poets, discuss verses, share interpretations and introduce others to Hindi, Urdu and contemporary poetry,” she says. “Poetry doesn’t feel distant or intimidating any longer.”

Bootwala cautions that spoken word may not necessarily turn into good books. “I have seen publishers trying to hop on to this trend. But there is a distinction between page poetry and spoken word. Something can connect when you listen to it, but it may lack the same impact when you read it,” he says.

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SPOKEN WORD VS WRITTEN VERSE

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YAHYA BOOTWALA @yahyabootwala 433K followers “While people listen to our spoken word, ‘boli zubaan’, they don’t stop there. Their interest in poetry is piqued. A lot of people have gone on to read poetry”

HOW POETRY EXISTS ON SOCIAL MEDIA

As performance: Poem comes directly to camera through voice, expression and personality. @whitneyhansonpoetry @olivia.poetess

As recitations: Existing poetry is recited, contextualised and given a contemporary visual treatment. @evermoreavalon, @deepshikhaa

As spoken word: Open-mic and stage performances get a second, much larger life as shareable clips and reels. @nayab.midha, @priyasometimes, @yahyabootwala

As shareable verse: A sher, couplet or few lines are shared as quote cards, carousels and videos. @poetic.abhay, @urdu.daan

partly by renewed interest in classics—the *Odyssey* effect. But according to *The Guardian* newspaper, contemporary poets with strong social-media audiences are also notching up sales.

In India, too, booksellers are seeing movement. Nidhi Gupta, director, Crossword Bookstore, says poetry sales have shown a “clear and steady growth” over the last two years. “We are seeing both contemporary poetry and classics finding readers. A new generation is discovering poetry, and the way they are discovering it has changed significantly.” Social media, she says, helps newer poets find readers while resurfacing older ones. “Sometimes a reader encounters just a few lines online, and that becomes the starting point for discovering the poet and eventually the book.”

In Crossword, younger readers are seeking out contemporary poets such as Rupri Kaur, Rithvik Singh and Sumitra Manda as well as well-known names, including Gulzar, Rumi, Khalil Gibran and Tagore. Relationships, separation, healing and personal experiences resonate strongly. Gupta says, “We are also seeing

poetry around identity, feminism and mental health.”

Sameer Mahale, VP-sales, Penguin Random House India (PRHI), says demand for poetry is encouraging. Poetry now increasingly sits within a broader “musings” space—short-form reflective writing—which he describes as one of the publisher’s faster-growing segments.

The new poetry buyer is younger, often in their 20s, and discovers the genre through social media, says Manoj Satti, senior VP-sales, product and marketing at PRHI. He adds, “Many are first-time poetry readers. What’s interesting is that this buyer doesn’t always fit the old idea of a ‘literary’ reader. They are building a personal relationship with poetry, one poem or one post at a time.”

Social media popularity doesn’t necessarily translate into big sales. Satti says, “Social media popularity does move books. But it is engagement and authenticity that decide how much.”

While Crossword is seeing category growth, Dharini Bhaskar, publisher, Fourth Estate and Perennial, HarperCollins India, says greater online visibility hasn’t translated into significant book sales. “There aren’t enough readers entering bookstores and buying the works of poets. Until this changes, until every reader who cares for poetry, who cares for writing, makes a conscious effort to buy a collection of poems, poetry will be viewed as a ‘niche’ market.”

For all the anxieties about what the reel is doing to poetry, perhaps the more interesting question is what happens after. Verma says, “For me, the feed has often been the beginning of the journey, not the end.”

Poetry just got reel.

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Apoorva Mittal

Padel is everyman’s racket sport—it shortened the tennis court, narrowed the net and lowered the entry barrier. People rushed to the courts, had a whole lot of fun—and some got hurt. Like Yash Mathur. The 33-year-old from Delhi was playing padel for over a year when he felt a nagging pain in his leg; his Achilles tendon had again flared up. He had to take a break from the sport and spend a few weeks recovering from the injury.

His physiotherapist has identified the muscles that need strengthening and built a routine of exercises around his padel sessions, which he now plays two-three times a week.

“Recovery is now harder for me than it was in my 20s when I played football,” says Mathur, VP-strategy, Nippon Audiotronix. “Warmups and post-match cool-downs are essential.”

He is part of a growing cohort of recreational players who are realising that padel’s relatively low barrier to entry does not necessarily mean low demands on the body. A racket sport that combines elements of squash and tennis, padel is typically played as a doubles game in an enclosed court. In India, it is gaining traction in cities such as Mumbai, Delhi, Chandigarh and Bengaluru. According to Hudle’s India Padel Report 2026, the number of courts in India has gone up to around 500 from 100 in 2023, while the number of players has grown to 100,000 from about 1,000.

As more and more Indians take up relatively easy racquet sports such as padel and pickleball, an unlikely cohort of professionals is getting more clients: physiotherapists, who point to a rise in ankle, wrist, knee and shoulder injuries. For some clinics, this is translating into a regular stream of patients requiring treatment.

LOVE ALL

Christopher Pedra, additional director, sports medicine, Sir HN Reliance Foundation Hospital, Mumbai, says padel isn’t a dangerous sport. However, its accessibility brings a large recreational population onto the court and allows people with vastly different fitness and skill levels to play together.

Unlike sports like tennis, squash or badminton, where large differences in ability can make a game difficult to sustain, the smaller enclosed padel court, use of walls and the doubles format make it easier for beginners to play alongside more experienced players. That means some players are moving from a relatively low base of physical activity to unfamiliar movements that are performed repeatedly at high intensity. The sport requires a fair amount of acceleration, deceleration and change of direction.

“The low barrier for entry means the average officegoer or weekend warrior plays a couple of games of padel a week,” says Pedra. “The sport is highly addictive, and the community is crazy about it.”

Injury Time

As people rush to play padel and pickleball, the risk of injuries has also gone up due to lack of adequate warmup, wrong footwear and subpar courts

Pedra says the number of injuries he sees as a result of padel has roughly doubled over the past two years. Among the recreational or “weekend warrior” patients he treats, he estimates padel could account for around 30% of cases.

Dr Paridhi Ojha, a Delhi-based sports physiotherapist, began noticing a rise in injuries due

to padel last year. “People do not go for a basic warmup. They think that because these are lesser-impact sports, they could just start playing. That’s the first mistake,” she says.

BREAK POINT

The problem is compounded by inappropriate footwear, with some recreational players turning up in running shoes or regular sneakers, and by the

social nature of the sport, adds Ojha. “People are using padel and pickleball as socialising options and considering them as easy sports, so they are overdoing them,” says Ojha. “They think they can play for hours. It starts with an hour, and then somebody else joins and suddenly they are playing for two hours. The body isn’t accustomed to that.”

Since the beginning of this year, Ojha has seen a jump in padel-related injuries. A similar pattern played out with pickleball earlier: two years ago, she saw a 150-200% increase in pickleball-related injuries.

For physiotherapists, each injury can mean multiple visits. Each session can cost around ₹2,500, while a 15-session rehabilitation package can cost around ₹20,000, depending on the clinic and physiotherapist. The number of sessions depends on the nature of

injury: a basic spasm may require one or two sessions, a strain five or six, while tendon and ligament injuries can require rehabilitation lasting 8 to 12 weeks.

Dr Richa Mishra, founder of Resurge Physiotherapy and Wellness Clinic in Pitampura, Delhi, says padel-related cases have become particularly visible over the past six months. Ankle sprains and tennis elbow are among the most frequent complaints, followed by serious injuries such as rotator cuff tears. Mishra estimates that padel players now account for 50-60% of sports-injury patients coming to her clinic. They are mostly between 20 and 45 years.

Her clinic is getting repeat cases, she says. “Players who don’t warm up properly or train specifically for the demands of their sport are more likely to suffer repeat injuries.”

Ojha recommends that players spend at least 15 minutes warming up and stretching before stepping on to the court, use appropriate footwear and work on core and cross-chain strength required for the sport.

The increase in patients does not necessarily mean padel has created an entirely new market for sports medicine. “The fact that people are coming in with more padel injuries means I’m probably seeing fewer five-a-side football injuries because a lot of the people who used to do that have moved to padel,” says Pedra. “It’s not that it has created

this wild new opportunity in medicine. It’s the same people who used to do other problematic things who have now changed to a new problematic thing.”

CHECK THE COURTS

The quality of courts may not have kept pace with the demand, says Suraj Veer Sharma, MD of Padel Pro India, a padel club network. He says clubs have a responsibility to educate new players on appropriate footwear, warmups, techniques and safe progression into the sport. “To minimise avoidable injuries, club owners should invest in quality infrastructure, regular court maintenance, and ensure consistent even playing surfaces.”

Keshav Singhania, 32, a chartered accountant who has been playing pickleball competitively for about two years, says he initially treated it as a recreational activity. After a largely sedentary working day, he would turn up at the court and start playing without preparing his body for the lateral movements and overhead shots the sport demanded.

After three or four injuries, including an ankle ligament tear that took around 45 days to heal, his approach changed. He plays four to five times a week, often for 60 to 90 minutes, but incorporates adequate warmup and plyometrics. “I now appreciate a warmup much better than I did when I started playing,” he says.

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Working Class Rice Just Got Nice, Now That It's Hit the Supper Club Circuit

For a prole dish that no Bengali babu, never mind lady, would be caught having, pantha bhaat sure has come a long way, baby, now being served up as superfood and poster-meal for zero-waste cooking

SUNDAY ROAST



RESHOM MAJUMDAR

London: I recently helped curate a pantha bhaat — cooked rice soaked and fermented in water — platter here in London, replete with fried ilish (hilsa), daler bora (lentil fritters), and all. This was for a room full of Sunday pot roast loyalists paying good money for a dish that, a generation ago, wasn't considered good enough for the domestic help's lunch break.

Pantha bhaat is riding the wave of Instagram buzz around this once-humble, now

hashtag-worthy dish back home in India. Turns out the internet has finally caught up to what grandmothers knew all along.

Pantha bhaat is historically one of the most looked-down-upon Bengali dishes. Relegated firmly to the background, it was a labourer's dish, never a lady's lunch, certainly not what the 'bhadralok' would be seen eating. Yet, for generations, the working man had this as his breakfast: rice soaked overnight, eaten cold, dressed with nothing more than a green chilli, a sliver of onion, and if the week had been generous, a fried fish on the side.

Cross into Odisha and the same idea shows up as pakhalā, old enough for a day to be named after it — Pakhalā Dibasa, celebrated every March 20. Assam has its poita bhat, eaten with potato mash and mustard oil. In Bihar and Jharkhand,



WET, YOUR APPETITE

soaked rice turns up as basi or gheel bhat. Chhattisgarh calls it bore basi. Tamil Nadu has its pazhaya sadam, mashed and loosened with curd. Kerala calls it pazham kanji, best eaten with pickle and fried coconut. Andhra Pradesh and Telangana serve up chaddannam. Different regions, changed nomenclature. But the same basic genius — nobody wanted to waste, so water was added to leftover rice, and the rising temperature did its own chemistry.

What I find rather delicious about this whole reversal of

fortune is that the dish didn't need reinventing to become fashionable. It just needed us to stop being snobs about it

What the soaking actually does is rather clever: It nudges rice to release the iron, calcium, and other minerals that would otherwise stay locked away, stubbornly out of reach of your body no matter how much rice you eat. The labourer eating his morning plate was, quite unknowingly, getting more nourishment out of his bowl than his employer ever got from a

plate of freshly steamed, 'proper' rice. The cloudy leftover liquid most refined households would have tipped down the drain without a second thought. That does unglamorous work of its own, the kind that keeps the gut happy, and immune system alert.

The body handles this rice rather well compared to a freshly cooked plate. It doesn't come at you all at once. Which means that the working man's breakfast was quietly managing his energy through a long day of labour better than anything London's wellness cafes are currently charging well over 10 quid for.

Which brings me back to pantha bhaat served up in London. Watching people who'd normally reach for avocado toast queue up for a dish once considered too plain for polite company has its own kind of vindication. The 'bhadralok' took a hundred years to come around to the working-class dish, but got there in the end. Sometimes the food that was never meant to impress anyone is exactly the food that ends up doing it best. Probiotics at no extra cost.

Let's talk about...
A Mocha Moment
Looks like the Houthi has ordered Mocha.
A coffee break in the middle of a war?
Not a mocha. Mocha. The historic Yemeni port city. Houthi forces have seized control of it after a major offensive against forces aligned with Yemen's Saudi-backed government.
This Mocha sounds familiar. Any relation to café mocha?
Well, the name. Some also say the origin story for moka-pot. Coffee, as you know and I hope you do, originated in Ethiopia, but Yemen does have a crucial role in turning it into a global commodity. It was the Sufi scholar Ali bin Omar al-Shadhili who first brought coffee to Mocha from Abyssinia. By the 16th century, beans grown in Yemen's highlands were being shipped through the port of Mocha to Egypt, the Ottoman Empire and eventually Europe.
The OG coffee capital?
Pretty much. For centuries, it was so closely associated with coffee that beans shipped through the port simply became known as 'Mocha'. The chocolate, however, came later. Yemeni coffee would have chocolatey notes and that gave it a distinct flavour. The modern-day café mocha adds chocolate to the coffee to mimic that taste.
But what happened to the Mocha coffee empire?
Coffee heists! Basically, other countries got the beans. The Dutch began cultivating coffee in Java and coffee production eventually spread across Asia and the Americas. Mocha's dominance faded. Yemen coffee is still around but it is now a niche producer rather than the coffee superpower it once was. In fact, Indian coffee owes its origins to this region. Legend has it that around 1670, Sufi pilgrim Baba Budan smuggled seven fertile coffee seeds out of Mocha, strapped to his body, and planted them in the hills of Mysore.
Whoa! What happens to Mocha now?
For now, unfortunately, its strategic location matters more than its coffee history. The Houthi capture puts them closer to the Bab el-Mandeb, through which a significant chunk of global trade and oil travels.
That's a whole 'latte' problem.
Indeed. For the region, it's 'bean' there, done that.
Text: Nupur Amarnath

One Slip-Up And SpikeJet Takes Your Trip

Buying air tickets online can be an exercise closer to quantum mechanics

So, a man is trying to buy two air tickets from Delhi to one of the mountain airports up north for a date towards October-end. He goes online to, let's just call it TakeMyTrip, and scans prices. At first, he gets what seem like crazily high prices — about ₹11,500 a ticket on, let's just call it, SpikeJet, shall we?

After exploring other airlines, he comes back to the SpikeJet page, and it's now offering much lower prices — around ₹6,500 per seat. He puts in passenger details and the date of flight, adding flight protection in case the flight is delayed.

He has to enter the details three times because the website doesn't seem to catch his keystrokes. But when it is done at 10 pm, he pays ₹13,540 for 2 tickets. When the ticket arrives in his mailbox, he goes into shock: the booked flight is for the next morning, not 58 days later, which is when he wants to fly.

The man then spends two hours trying to salvage the situation. First, he goes to SpikeJet and tries to cancel the tickets. He sees he will get back only ₹2,464, losing about ₹11,000. Then he remembers he has purchased a free date change, so he tries that.

Hah, hah — the date change is free, but the additional price for flying on the desired day takes the cost up to the originally crazy-seeming ₹11,500 a ticket.

The man tries calling the airline. For his trouble, he gets 15 minutes of: 'Our agents are currently dealing with other customers, please hold. Your call is important to us.'

It's like a hypnotic cult chant, but thankfully there's no intervening muzak to fry his brain further. He hangs up and calls the large insurance company that provides the date-change protection he purchased, and here he lucks out. Or seems to. A polite human tells him the travel department will help him and connects him. The man stays on the call for 22 min and 15 secs: 'Please hold. All our customer care executives are busy. We will speak to you shortly.'

The man goes back to SpikeJet and connects with the chatbot. He has decided he will pay the extra amount for the date change. The SpikeJet chatbot is friendly, prompt, and clear: 'Total extra payable ₹9,842. Would you like to confirm this change and pay the extra amount of ₹9,842?' The man confirms. The next message: 'Please pay ₹16,048 to confirm your booking.'

The man yelps at the chatbot: 'YOU JUST SAID ₹9,842!' The chatbot is unmoved: 'I have clarified with my executive. The final amount is ₹16,048.' ₹13,000 plus ₹16,000 makes it ₹29,000, a chunk more than the initial ₹11,500 x 2 = ₹23,000. Somewhere, the AI chatbot (or the exec behind it) has understood that this hapless moron of a customer is helpless, and that it's time to turn on the lemon squeezer. The man girds the bullet, bites his loins, and cancels the booking.

The message from TakeMyTrip says the refund will be ₹2,464. The amount that arrives is ₹1,166. The final damage being around ₹12,400 for a brief mistake on two glitchy, trap-filled websites.

What could be the solution? Here are 3 suggestions:

- Before final payment is initiated and accepted, the exact flight, date and cost should be displayed in large, clear fonts.
- There should be an option for no-cost, no-questions-asked cancellation within 2 hours of any air-ticket purchase.
- All surge-pricing skulduggery should be banned. Even if the customer missed checking the flight date, there's no way the price for an end-October flight went up by ₹3,000 a ticket in the 2 hours between 10 pm and midnight in early September.

That was pure robbery, to add to the general, all-pervading digital sleight of hand. Some consumers would say there should also be an additional penalty for the hub website and airline for putting the customer through extra bheja-frying.

Is Your 'World-Class' Really Worthwhile?

Wanting quality – in our food, buildings, roads, life – is all very well, until you realise it means the end of jugaad

RED HERRING



INDRAJIT HAZRA

One true measure of our genius for assessing things is the use of the word 'world-class'. It's a description that's particularly Indian, in the sense that no one uses the term to describe the Fifa World Cup as a 'world-class' tournament, or the Uffizi in Florence to be a 'world-class' art gallery, or the A24 stretch of the autobahn connecting Hamburg to Berlin as a 'world-class' road. It's only used to describe wonderment when applied to an experience in India. Guru just won't do. It'll have to be Vishwaguru.

True superlatives, when applied here to a restaurant meal, a hotel stay, a metro ride experience, a university, a digital payment system, a swimming pool, or even a nephew's school theatre production, can be deemed 'world-class'. They may well be great. But the point is that to register that something is truly awesome, 'world-class' is the apogee of praise you'll need to take out of your toolkit for others to sit up and take note.

But what is 'world-class'? Statistical-

ly, the world isn't a paragon of excellence. Most of the 195 countries in the world struggle with shoddy construction, chaotic traffic, dubious hygiene, and education systems that produce the sort of things you read on Truth Social. If 'world-class' is meant to reflect the average of global practice, then the benchmark is depressingly low.

But, of course, that's not what is meant by 'world-class' here. It is meant to mean outstanding quality that places a person, group, or thing at the peak of their field—ranking among the very best in the entire world. The trouble is, 'world-class' aspirations are not always accompanied by 'world-class' standards and practices.

Recently, I went to an outlet of a Chinese restaurant chain. This particular branch rated high on food delivery apps — 4.5 (out of 5) on Swiggy, 4.2 on Zomato, both with more than 2,000 ratings. The moment I stood outside Denzong Kitchen in reasonably upmarket southern Kolkata, I sensed something

HOLD THAT POSE

odd: right at the mouth of the restaurant facing the footpath was the door-less kitchen. Where was the seating area?

Perhaps, this was an only-takeaway joint. But upon enquiry, I was told to go up a narrow flight of wooden stairs that led to a mezzanine floor that looked like a perfect transit station for human trafficking. With my order taking far longer than I hoped for, I went downstairs to the kitchen a few times. What I saw horrified me — from the cooking area, to where the dishes were cleaned (sic), to the way the food was being prepared. It was a wet organic nightmare even by my Pigeon hygiene standards.

A few weeks later, I learnt of the crackdown on restaurants, eateries, and mithai shops by Kolkata Municipal Corporation that's still in full-swing. Coming as it has in the run-up to next month's Durga Puja, there's quite an outcry on how the new dispen-

sation is cracking down on well-known establishments 'for no rhyme or reason', some even assigning a sinister 'non-veg food hatao' drive to the whole thing. A Denzong Kitchen outlet does feature in the 40-odd eateries whose licences have been suspended. But as I write this, the outlet I visited is certainly taking orders. Because of

'World-class' aspirations aren't always accompanied by 'world-class' standards and practices

technical issues, you are unable to hear me retching at the thought of it. What is true of disturbingly filthy restaurant kitchens, could be true for other arenas. When pavements illegally encroached upon by shacks and shops are cleared, there's an outcry. 'Where will the people go? How will we have a quick chai?' When leaky NEET exams are suspended to have them plugged, after the initial outrage against corruption, there's an outcry. 'How will my kid get into medical college? A bribe would have got him/her in.' Jumping a queue is so normalised that not being allowed to jump a queue becomes a human right violation.

People may be all for 'world-class'. But when they want to, say, add a minimum-hassle extension to their third floor, cutting corners and dodging regulations are seen as perfectly kosher lubricating jugaad. So, be careful of what 'world-class' viksit fix its you wish for. It may mean making worldly sacrifices you're not willing to make. Certainly not till 2047.

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Desi Bhai, Tech Bros, & A Bit of Tagore in Frisco

Peek into how America's tech capitalism boom's equal parts curse and blessing

SUNDAY SAPIEN



ATEESH TANKHA

During a recent visit to San Francisco, I discovered that it takes only a small suspension of disbelief to be persuaded that the tech boom and its attendant wealth creation are equal parts curse and blessing. Nothing brings this fact home more persuasively than the growing number of homeless people in Frisco's Tenderloin district, and other parts of town.

Largely ignored or resented by the city's tax-paying residents, and lightly confined and prodded by the authorities, their hopelessness and hunger are a reminder of what happens when labour is optimised by insatiable efforts of en-



CALIFORNIA NOT DREAMIN'

lightened capitalism. Efficiency, as all the AI-hijacked billboards proclaim, is a zero-sum game, which drives either conformity and profit, or redundancy and exclusion. A public mural captures this succinctly. Above an image of a fallen Statue of Liberty, brought down in chains by automated machines, is inscribed a fragment from Emma Lazarus' 1893 poem, 'The New Colossus': '... Give me your tired, your poor, your huddled masses yearning to be free,

The wretched refuse of your teeming shore. Send these, the homeless, tempest-tost to me, I lift my lamp beside the golden door.'

Nearby, a tableau vivant — a woman with earphones and a large grocery bag, who has just exited a driverless Waymo taxi, cocks a snook at two street-dwellers sharing a sandwich — unfolds perfectly. I made my despondent way to a meet up with a college acquaintance. Over coffee, she shared a recent experience. The night before, she had accosted a loud tourist from India at a hotel bar telling his almost adult son that Rabindranath Tagore, on his second visit to the US and while staying at the same Palace Hotel in

Efficiency drives either conformity and profit, or redundancy and exclusion

1916, was nearly assassinated by the revolutionary Ghadar Party. 'Why did they want to kill him?' asked the youngster. 'Because, at that time, he was a British chancha,' replied the man with certitude. 'But what did he do?' persisted the son. 'Nothing,' concluded the father: 'He was unprepared to support the cause of our independence struggle.'

'Not quite,' my friend found herself interjecting. 'But he was unwilling to condone violence, and

put the concept of society above that of a nation state.'

His first reaction at hearing her unexpected voice was to stiffen and then, so it seemed to her, to turn and flee. But he gave her the once-over and felt more confident confronting somebody he considered a mere compatriot.

'Nation stands above society. It has taken India too long to understand this. Thankfully, it is now coming to its senses. We will do great things.'

'Yes... but a nation usually forces the marriage of politics and commerce to streamline the efforts of individuals. Then we become slaves of the system.'

'Maybe,' shrugged her interlocutor. 'But slaves are better than beggars.'

'But the system creates beggars. As one group becomes richer, another must become poorer. Just look at this city.'

'Look at India, instead,' he countered. 'Have you seen the latest growth figures? When we are great again, we will never permit filthy kangals on our streets.'

'Seriously? Do you believe...? Are you a leftist?' he interrupted her, mid-sentence.

'No, only an observer,' she assured him.

'Oh, a dimagi naxal, then.'

Before she could protest, he mumbled 'Jai Hind' and left. Just as she was about to leave, she spied a pair of tech bros weaving their way unsteadily from the bar to the exit. 'We have to stop treating people like they are numbers,' said one. She felt a stirring of hope. Perhaps, Americans understood Tagore better than her own countrymen.

'Why?' asked the other. 'In FSD [full self-driving] crash test simulation, the programme chose to compromise the passenger and scrape the divider because the alternative showed four homeless people crossing the road. We've got to make it realise the relative worth of each individual. Those four had none.'

It may have been the drink, but she swore that she spied a white, bearded, South Asian apparition in a long cloak depart with the two techies through the hotel's revolving door.

The writer is MD, eTrans Solutions



ET Sunday Crossword

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ACROSS

- Clear of trees, author Daniel gathers rare stone (8)
- Skinny boat loses prow in Delphi perhaps (6)
- Foreign citizens reduced? Charge less (8)
- Sundry tabloids to put out unscripted comments (2,4)
- If science sadly lacks satisfactory expertise (10)
- Incline to follow groom's party

DOWN

- He could, after training, save litres in shower (6)
- Manipulate sweet (5)
- 24 are thin on the ground (4)
- Slip away, provided entertainment's over on time (5,2)
- Arm supporters and organise raid on capital of Indonesia (5)
- These customers need gin to supply intelligence (9)
- Writer, for instance, lives in English street (4)
- One fellow in Hawaii supplies audio equipment (2-2)
- Fine choreographer retains predecessor of fox trot (4)
- Bonnet, perhaps, from early years (9)
- Cut top of grass and top of barley, say (3)
- Humorous party beside ancient city (4)
- What furious people do when rookie enters small golf club (8)
- Nobleman met a prole occasionally (4)
- It could be very serious in future, perhaps (7)
- In spring, eyes deteriorate in Greece (6)
- Pity about Europe losing its money, some in India (5)
- Bygone era's first adhesive (5)
- Trim magazine (4)

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Trump says Open to China Building Cars in the US



Bloomberg

New York: President Donald Trump suggested he might be willing to allow a Chinese car company to build electric vehicles in the US if it did so with American workers, while pledging to maintain the effective US ban on imported vehicles from China.

Trump, speaking in a Fox News interview, rejected the suggestion that he would allow Chinese cars to be imported into the US. “We don’t allow his cars into the United States, and we never did,” Trump said, referring to Chinese leader Xi Jinping, adding that if that wasn’t the case the US automobile market would be “over-run.”

“Now, if China wanted to come in, and open a plant to build their cars here, I’d be okay with it — Japan does it — but they hire our people,” Trump said. “The big thing is they hire our people, they use our people.”

“What I don’t want is them to build in Mexico and just, you know, build it inexpensively and ship it across the border,” he said. “That’s un-happening.”

Cheap, tech-laden Chinese EVs from companies like BYD and Geely Automobile Holdings Ltd are rapidly gaining global market share. They’re also appearing in both Canada and Mexico, amplifying concerns among US auto executives that they could soon seek inroads in America.

Currently, Chinese vehicles are essentially shut out of the US market by steep tariffs and a Commerce Department ban on national security grounds that covers so-called connected vehicle systems from US adversaries including China. Trump’s comments come weeks before a planned summit with Xi in Washington, though he has made similar remarks before.

US Companies Get Creative as Tariff Refunds Start Flowing in

From rewarding employees to paying down debt, firms are putting tariff refunds to work

Bloomberg

New York: US companies getting refunds after the Supreme Court struck down President Donald Trump’s import tariffs are using the temporary windfall in a range of creative ways.

The refunds are being used to cover rising costs, supplement employee retirement accounts and repay debt. Some are sharing the bounty with vendors. And a number of consumer companies are beefing up their assortment of lower-priced products and offering deals to attract budget-conscious shoppers pinched by the rising cost of living.

Companies in the Russell 3000 Index mentioned tariff refunds almost 1,000 times in earnings calls and filings in July, August and September, according to a Bloomberg News analysis, almost four times more than in the previous earnings season. Consumer discretionary and staples companies accounted for more than a third of the references, disclosing the receipt of close to \$9.8 billion in refunds during that period.

Roughly \$166 billion was paid in tariffs under the International Emergency Economic Powers Act, or IEEA.

On the Money

\$9.8b in tariff refunds received by consumer staples companies

\$166b paid in tariffs under IEEPA before the law was overturned

Williams-Sonoma: \$200m refund; \$10m directed to employee 401(k)s

Funko: Sold \$22m in refund claims for \$19.2m cash

Xerox: Recognised \$105m in refunds and sold receivable for \$80m

Walmart: Using refunds for temporary discounts & deals

Elf Beauty: Using part of its \$50m refund to lower prices on 10% of products

Kohl's: Sharing refunds with vendors and increasing inventory

Academy Sports: Used refund proceeds mainly to lower prices

PA, which was overturned in February. Executives were initially reluctant to discuss their plans for pursuing refunds as they assessed criticism from the president and legal challenges from consumers seeking their share of the payouts.

They’ve been more forthcoming in recent months as the refunds started rolling in. Williams-Sonoma said in late August that it put \$10 million of the \$200 million it received back toward employee 401(k) contributions. It also paid \$47.5 million to vendors

who gave the retailer discounts on inventory purchases to offset tariff costs.

“We’re so appreciative to have the money back and to be able to reward our employees with part of it,” Williams-Sonoma CEO Laura Alber said on a call with analysts.

Kohl’s Corp shared some of the roughly \$150 million in refunds with vendors who paid more to import inventory from manufacturers while the tariffs were in effect. Chief financial officer Jill Timm told analysts

the company also reinvested cash in its business, including boosting inventory levels for its lower-priced brands. Some companies have opted to take advantage of a growing secondary market for tariff claims, since chasing down the exact amount due can be a lengthy process.

Funko, the parent of Funko Pops and other collectibles brands, said it sold more than \$22 million in tariff refund claims for \$19.2 million to a third-party financial institution and used some of the proceeds to pay down a term loan. Printer maker Xerox Holdings Corp recognised \$105 million in tariff refunds, then sold the receivable to a third party for \$80 million in cash to help reduce its debt load, executives said.

Academy Sports & Outdoors recorded \$83.7 million in refunds, then sold \$72.2 million of the claims to a third party for \$10.5 million.

Walmart said on its August earnings call that some of its refund was going into temporary discounts and deals. Elf Beauty plans to use some of the \$50 million it received to lower prices on roughly 10% of its products.

While companies are starting to get some money back, it’s just temporary relief.

Special Rights

►► From Page 1

Tata Trusts is the umbrella organisation of a clutch of public charities that are majority owners of Tata Sons. All important decisions now need the vote of assent by directors nominated by the trust, effectively creating different classes of shareholders and directors.

As Tata Sons will need to turn itself into a public limited company ahead of listing, a class of shareholders cannot enjoy special rights and that might end this particular route through which the trusts exercised control. To be sure, the trusts will continue to be majority owners and will be able to exercise control through normal mechanisms available to majority owners.

For the debt-ridden Shapoorji-Paltonji Group, which owns an 18% stake in Tata Sons, the move will open up liquidity that it desperately needs. For a number of listed group companies that are equity owners in the parent, the liquidity of the

shares held on their balance sheets could prompt a rerating of their valuation in the stock markets.

If listed, Tata Sons will doubtless become a marquee, blue-chip stock, as it effectively provides exposure to a number of important sectors of the Indian economy, typically via ownership in companies that enjoy market leadership. The central bank’s decision follows a revision of its scale-based regulatory framework in June 2026, when it set an asset threshold of ₹1 lakh crore for classifying an entity as an upper-layer NBFC.

Tata Sons had total assets of ₹2.01 lakh crore as of March 31, 2026, more than twice the threshold. The value of its holdings in the listed companies alone add up to ₹12 lakh crore, while it also has holdings in a number of large unlisted companies, whose values are as yet unknown. A listing will also become a massive valuation exercise.

The company had repaid all its debt in an effort to secure deregistration and avoid a listing. However, the RBI’s eligibility conditions stipulate that only entities that do not

hold public funds, have no customer interface and possess assets of less than ₹1,000 crore can qualify for deregistration by December 31.

Tata Sons, whose interests range from steel and automobiles to financial services and semiconductors, has featured among upper-layer NBFCs since 2022.

The central bank has also said that once an NBFC is classified in the upper layer, it will remain subject to the stricter regulatory framework for at least five years, even if it no longer meets the eligibility criteria in subsequent assessments.

RBI governor Sanjay Malhotra had earlier said the revised rules on upper layer NBFC classification was principle-based. “So, as per those principles, everyone knows what the list is. And so that is where the matter stands,” Malhotra said in response to a question on whether Tata Sons would remain in the upper layer.

Tata Trusts, which controls 66% of Tata Sons through the Sir Ratan Tata Trust and the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust, passed a resolution in July 2025 seeking to keep the holding company privately owned.

MBS Seeks Military Help

►► From Page 1

Washington now faces a dilemma over whether to help the Saudis fight the Houthis, risking further expansion of the war. Saudi Arabia’s de facto ruler, Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, phoned Trump on Thursday and asked for US military help fighting the Houthis, three sources said. They said the prince was told that Washington would not intervene directly for now but would help with intelligence. Trump confirmed on Saturday that he had spoken to the crown prince, and said the Houthis had also phoned his administration and asked Washington not to become directly involved in the conflict. Four Yemeni government sources told Reuters that the Houthis had seized the strategic island of Perim on Friday in the middle of the Babel-Mandeb Strait — the “Gate of Tears” at the mouth of the Red Sea.

Challenges Ahead

►► From Page 1

The board acts on the recommendations of the committee, which is a subset of the full board.

As the group navigates the regulatory and capital-markets shift, a change of leadership at the helm would prove doubly challenging, said one official. While Chandrasekaran has indicated that he does not intend to seek another term beyond February 2027, the prospect of a listing could strengthen the argument for retaining him for a defined period.

His institutional knowledge and experience in steering the group would make a compelling case as Tata Sons prepares to operate under greater scrutiny as a listed entity.

If Chandra were to reconsider his decision, it would need the support of Tata Trusts as he would need to be reappointed as director at an annual general body meeting, which is currently in abeyance as key shareholder Sir Ratan Tata Trust has been suspended by the Maharashtra Charity Commissioner from making important decisions, pending an inquiry into whether the trust is in violation of norms.

Jobs in Metros in Demand

►► From Page 1

It has also started listing jobs in India, and interest in those roles is rising.

India-based job views on the platform rose nearly threefold to 22,312 till July 2026 from 8,052 in 2023.

“For international students, getting the first job is only one part of the equation. The ability to secure sponsorship, build a long-term career and remain in the country increasingly factors into where they choose to start their careers,” said Tripti Maheshwari, cofounder of Student Circus, which partners with universities including Leeds, Bristol and Imperial College London.

Most graduates using the platform are looking for jobs in metro cities such as Bengaluru, Mumbai, Gurugram and Hyderabad.

VISAS DICTATING CAREER CHOICES

Divya S, 26, worked as a social work officer in London. As her visa neared its end, she began weighing a return. Her employer did not sponsor visas, even as the UK tightened its visa criteria. “Towards the end, I think like my last six months over there, they also tightened the visa criteria,” she said.

By October last year, Divya had shifted to applying only for jobs in India. She eventually found one in April this year, but said several friends who returned around the same time are still unemployed.

“I know seven-eight people who are literally unemployed right now and they’re not getting a job,” she said.

The shift comes amid a growing number of people leaving the UK. According to the Office for National Statistics, an estimated 278,000 non-European Union nationals left the UK long-term in the year ending 2025. In-

dians were the largest nationality within this group, followed by Chinese nationals.

BEYOND BRITISH ISLES

The trend is not limited to the UK. A growing number of Indians abroad are finding that immigration rules and visa uncertainty are affecting their career plans.

The United States is seeing a similar trend, with some Indian professionals returning to India amid uncertainty over visas.

“Returnee volumes have risen every year, and the gap between outbound and returning talent continues to narrow. H-1B policy is one factor, with the new petition fee and shifting green card rules making it harder to plan and underwrite a multi-year horizon,” said Kapil Joshi, chief executive of IT staffing at Quest Corp.

COMING HOME HAS A COST

But returning home does not necessarily mean more jobs or higher salaries. A recent survey by an anonymous community app for job seekers Blind found that many returnees are joining the India offices of the same multinational companies they previously worked for in the US, but at significantly lower salaries.

The survey of 1,276 verified professionals in India found that 53% had seen people return from the US because of visa-related issues. Of these, 36% said colleagues or job candidates had already returned, while another 17% knew people planning to come back. The visa squeeze is also reaching students. The post-study stay period for international students in the UK is being shortened, with the graduate visa duration falling from two years to 18 months for applications made from January next year.

(Names of returnees have been changed to protect identity)

UNSC Expansion

►► From Page 1

In preparing the governance reform road map, Modi suggested that BRICS keep three key aspects in mind—representation, responsiveness and rule-making.

“First, with regard to representation, I would like to say that reform of the UN Security Council can no longer be delayed. The text-based negotiations on this issue must be linked to a clearly defined timeline and concrete outcomes,” he said. “Similarly, in financial institutions, voting power, leadership positions, and policy priorities should reflect today’s economic realities. Countries that drive global economic growth should also have an appropriate role in shaping global economic governance.”

BRICS, it may be pointed out, has been calling for reform of the IMF and the World Bank. “Second, responsiveness: Global institutions will earn the trust of humanity only when they are able to provide effective solutions to global challenges. We must focus on the speed, scale, and last-mile impact of our collective response,” Modi said.

On rule-making, he said the Global South needs to evolve from being “rule-takers into rule-shapers.” Chinese President Xi Jin-

ping said the West Asia war doesn’t serve “common interests” in his remarks at the session. He also urged the BRICS countries to strengthen cooperation on artificial intelligence besides calling on BRICS to oppose violations of other countries’ sovereignty and interference in their internal affairs.

Russian President Vladimir Putin called for United Nations reforms, echoing India’s views and backing its claims for a seat in an expanded Security Council. The Indian Prime Minister also laid emphasis on unity among BRICS nations on the 20th anniversary of the grouping amid differences among members, particularly in West Asia.

“BRICS too stands at a ‘coming of age’ moment. Over the past 10 years, BRICS has established a distinct identity for itself on the global stage. We respect each other’s perspectives and move forward through consensus. We strive to move ahead with an approach that is not against anyone but instead seeks to take everyone along,” he said.

“It is now time for us to translate our unity and consensus within BRICS into concrete outcomes on the global stage. For the next 20 years, we must work on a new and ambitious agenda. We must begin by strengthening our own working systems.” Amid attacks on

Indian seafarers in West Asia and the Black Sea region, Modi also focused on the welfare of seafarers. India is the second biggest contributor to the seafaring community.

“Seafarers make a very significant contribution to global trade, yet they often find themselves without adequate support during times of difficulty,” Modi said. “I propose whether we can establish a Seafarers Emergency Support Network. This network could connect the maritime authorities and missions of the countries concerned. It could facilitate distress alerts, medical assistance, communication with families, and support for evacuation.”

In yet another forward-looking suggestion, Modi suggested a mechanism for continuity among BRICS presidencies.

“The BRICS chairship changes every year, but this should not interrupt our institutional momentum,” the PM said. “I propose the establishment of a BRICS Continuity and Implementation Mechanism. Through the troika, this mechanism will ensure systematic follow-up on all initiatives and outcomes.” China will hold the next BRICS presidency followed by South Africa.

The Indian PM also suggested that BRICS can create a secure digital repository in which, for every decision, the nodal point, timeline, and implementation status can be recorded. The PM referred to India’s BRICS chairship, which is guided by a people-centric and humanity-first approach.

Second Option More in Favour

►► From Page 1

In a consultation paper released on Saturday, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) proposed two alternatives to determine the settlement price of index and single-stock derivatives on expiry days.

The first is a blended VWAP (volume-weighted average price), which would use trades executed during the last 30 minutes of the continuous, or regular, trading session (CTS) and the 10-minute CAS. The contribution of each period would be based on the actual traded value, without assigning any predetermined weight to prices discovered through either the closing auction (CAS) or the cash market (CTS).

“The key objective is to reduce the disconnect between the cash-market price discovery and derivatives trading near the close,” said Rajesh Palviya, head of research at Axis Securities.

Currently, the closing prices of indices and the 200-odd stocks that are part of the derivatives segment are determined in the CAS. Before August 3, these levels were decided on the basis of the VWAP prices in the last 30 minutes of trade. In the CAS session, buy and sell orders are collected instead of being executed immediately.

The shift to the auction system was aimed at making the closing price more efficient and reducing the impact of orders placed near the end of the session.

But a drop in volumes during CAS and uncertainty over the indicative values of Nifty and Sensex kept market participants on edge, with options traders complaining of sharp losses on expiry days.

The second option put forward by

Sebi is to temporarily revert to the older system — the VWAP methodology, under which only trades executed during the last 30 minutes of a continuous trading session would be considered.

Sebi said this could remain in place for at least one year before a possible transition to the blended methodology, subject to adequate liquidity participation and market familiarity with CAS. The regulator sought public comments on the proposals by October 3. Market participants are more in favour of the second option of reverting to the VWAP system for now.

“Option 2 would be the best approach as it would give the market more time to adjust before a possible shift to a blended settlement, but Option 1 is also workable and could reduce the impact of orders that seek to influence CAS price discovery,” said Marwadi Shares and Finance chief executive Samir Doshi.

Sebi also proposed discontinuing the dissemination of the indicative index value (IIV) derived from security-level indicative equilibrium prices (IEP) during CAS. The regulator said the IEP, which is the estimated closing price if the auction ended at that moment, is an evolving indication based on orders in the auction book and does not represent an actual traded price.

On market timings, Sebi proposed two alternatives. One option is that trading for CAS stocks would continue until 3:30 pm, followed by CAS from 3:31 pm to 3:40 pm, with derivatives trading continuing until 3:45 pm. The other is that trading for CAS stocks would close at 3:15 pm, CAS would run until 3:25 pm, and derivatives trading would end at 3:30 pm.

Banking Regulator Nod Needed

►► From Page 1

The board approved the reappointment of V Srinivasa Rangan as a whole-time director, designated as executive director, for one year until November 22, 2027, subject to RBI approval.

It also approved the appointment of Jimmy Tata as a whole-time director, designated as executive director, for three years from the date of RBI approval. Tata is currently chief credit officer of the bank.

The bank further decided to create one additional whole-time di-

rector position, which will increase the number of whole-time directors on its board to four, apart from the MD and CEO.

HDFC Bank said the additional position would provide “sharper synergy and oversight,” including over its subsidiaries, while creating a larger pipeline for succession planning.

The fourth whole-time director will be selected in consultation with the new MD and CEO after the incoming chief takes charge.

Necessary shareholder approvals will be sought in due course, the bank said.

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Shoot Responsibly

When content is work, what works as content

For creator Shenaz Treasury, who has created content everywhere — from restaurants and airports to the Australian Open and football matches — the rule is simple: “Your content should never become somebody else’s problem.” That means phone over paraphernalia and speed over perfection. “I don’t do multiple takes. One take and I’m done. If it’s not perfect, that’s fine. Sometimes the imperfection actually makes the content better.” Digital creator Devika Khade agrees. “If people around you have started noticing or getting affected, you’ve gone too far.” She avoids large set-ups and repeated takes and says staff shouldn’t be expected to stop working to help create content unless it has been coordinated beforehand. Naman Kapoor offers a more creator-first take. “I honestly follow a rule I heard on *Suits*: ‘Forgiveness is always better than permission.’” He usually shoots first and shows the person afterwards, removing them if they remain uncomfortable. Too many rules, he argues, can affect creativity. His philosophy? “It’s not think and upload; it’s upload and think.” Treasury says the etiquette rule is simple: “Take the photo, make the reel, get the memory — just remember that there are other humans in the room.”



“There’s a funny contradiction now: Creators are invited specifically to create content, but then, people get annoyed when they create content. Clear rules make it easier for everyone. But we can’t put everything on venues either. Some of it is common sense. Being invited somewhere doesn’t mean the entire place suddenly becomes your set”

— Shenaz Treasury



“This is still a relatively new space. Everyone is figuring out the rules and guidelines, and people are bound to make mistakes. We’re all human. In fact, I don’t necessarily think there should be too many rigid rules, because I feel like that can affect creativity”

— Naman Kapoor



“Creators today do need a stronger sense of etiquette because we’re no longer just taking a picture for ourselves, we’re broadcasting an entire environment to thousands or millions of people. Being a creator shouldn’t mean being unaware of the space you’re in”

— Devika Khade

Eats, Shoots & Leaves

An Influencer's Guide to Public Spaces

Zero civic sense,” declared influencer Amulya Rattan after a pedestrian had the temerity to walk through her frame while she filmed a fit check in a public space. The internet promptly clapped back, making it a meme. Rattan is not alone in testing the boundaries of public space. Indore influencer Prakriti Gaur landed in legal trouble after allegedly lying on a zebra crossing while shooting a reel. And in August, a video showing two girls fighting over making reels at Bengaluru’s Cubbon Park went viral. Last year, influencers Varun Yadav and Aarush Bhola blasted music on a Bluetooth speaker in-flight, captioning it “*Hawa mein bhi badmaashi*.” Now, influencers at the US Open have been criticised for photoshoots, bright lights and filming during match play. When everyone’s a content creator, perhaps ‘civic sense’ needs a social-media update—and a manner manual for the creator era.

nupur.amarnath@timesofindia.com & pratishtha.bagai@timesofindia.com

After influencers at the US Open were spotted clicking pics with ring lights while matches were underway, Wimbledon tightened its rules around creators. **Nupur Amarnath** and **Pratishtha Bagai** put together a guide to creating ‘main character’ content without becoming the villain on the scene

Manner For Creator Age

When is filming an intrusion?

For etiquette experts, it’s when your content starts changing everyone else’s experience. “Etiquette in a gist implies respectfully co-existing with others in any given environment,” says Sunayna A Hak, etiquette and personality coach. Fame, she argues, should bring greater responsibility, not a licence to treat every person or place as a content opportunity. Etiquette trainer and coach Suneeta Sodhi Kanga gets more specific. “Lights and tripods are, I feel, extremely rude to carry with you, especially lights.” Keep commentary low, don’t block views with endless retakes and make photographs quick. At restaurants, she adds: “Don’t let the food get cold because you’re taking so many pictures and others are just waiting to eat.” People aren’t props. Don’t monopolise communal facilities, turn friends or staff into an unpaid production crew or assume strangers want a cameo in your reel. And being invited to create content isn’t a carte blanche. “Just because you have been invited or you’re expected to work, you must be mindful of the other patrons or attendees,” Kanga says.

The Creator Code

The dos and don’ts for creating in public

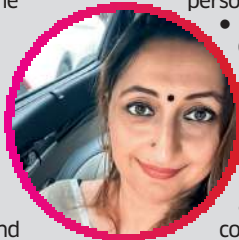
DOs

- Know the rules of the venue before filming
- Respect the host – and everyone sharing the space
- Ask for consent before filming, tagging or posting identifiable people, especially children
- Keep quiet where silence matters – tennis, golf, chess and other events
- Disclose sponsorships and paid promotions clearly

DON'Ts

- Treat every person or place as a content opportunity
- Intrude into someone’s personal space for a shot
- Use flash, talk loudly or record yourself when it disrupts play or others
- Direct insults, threats or profanity at players, coaches or referees
- Fake or exaggerate content simply to chase views and followers

Sunayna A Hak, etiquette and personality coach



CHECKLIST
Before posting: Check what your footage/caption implies; look for unnecessary faces, private conversations, children’s details, bills and phone screens.
If someone objects: Consider correction, blurring or removal. Respect a refusal without turning it into more content.

“Someone agreeing to speak to you is not necessarily agreeing to appear on your public account”
— Yukti Gupta, founding partner, Thistle&Law

“The creator is representing the brand throughout the process, not only when the camera is rolling”
— Jag Chima, co-founder, IPLIX Media

WEEKEND POSER

What Exactly Is A ‘Gut Feeling’?



Trisha Pasricha, MD

You meet someone at a party and want to like them, but something feels off. It’s hard to pinpoint what it is, but you just get a bad feeling inside. We often call this sensation a ‘gut feeling’, and we’ve been conditioned to trust it — sometimes blindly. But gut feelings are simply neurochemical signals that lead to a change in your stomach’s electrical rhythm — and not, in fact, an oracle.

SIGNALLING CASCADE

Researchers have found that people who make quick judgements based on gut feelings more often misjudge the emotions of others — compared to people who employ a systematic way of thinking. Studies evaluating emergency medicine physicians — who constantly make rapid life-or-death decisions — have found that relying on gut feelings led to the right diagnosis in only about 54% of cases. Certain triggers in our daily lives — stress, novelty, even prior memories — cause parts of our brain to release a molecule called the corticotropin-releasing hormone. This kicks off a signalling cascade through the vagus nerve, the main communication highway between the gut and the brain, and that message grinds the stomach to a rapid halt. Here’s where things get really fascinating: The butterflies you feel on an exciting first date are, on a molecular level, at least partly the same phenomenon as when you’re caught telling a lie and you feel your stomach tying itself into a knot. Yet one of them feels wonderful and urges you to charge ahead, while the other makes you ill and want to disappear. Why? The difference is context.

RESTORE RHYTHM

So, what can you do if you get a gut feeling but you can’t focus because your stomach is doing somersaults? Luckily, you can lean into the physiology. Your stomach’s reaction is dependent on signals travelling through the vagus nerve. So you can use a vagal manoeuvre to interrupt it: Try slow breathing with a focus on extending the exhale, for instance, or place a bag of ice cubes or frozen veggies over your face as you hold your breath for about 15 to 30 seconds. Not only will you calm a racing heart, but you’ll help restore the regular rhythm of your gut as well. — The Washington Post



It’s that time of the year when nail-biting thrillers, scintillating dramas and revealing memoirs all jostle for position to reach the Christmas number one. Here are some books you may be bagging from the bestseller stands this autumn:

1 MURDER AT THE GRAND ALPINE HOTEL by Lucy Foley

The bestselling crime writer pays homage to Agatha Christie’s Miss Marple in this wintry murder-mystery set in the Swiss Alps, marking 50 years since the detective’s last outing. When one of an eclectic mix of guests enters a gondola alive, only to be found dead at the top of the mountain, it’s clear there’s a killer in their midst.

2 REDWOOD by Ben Macintyre

Macintyre — author of hits such as SAS: *Rogue Heroes* and *Operation Mincemeat* — is back with his latest historical work. This time, he transports readers to Tehran in 1981, in the midst of the Iranian Revolution, with the Americans and Russians locked in the Cold War. It traces the true story of a double agent, dubbed ‘Redwood’ by MI6, a Russian intelligence officer who promised the British some of the KGB’s deepest secrets, in return for being smuggled out of Iran.

3 THRESHING DAY by Rebecca Yarros

This is a key release for romantasy fans, in which Yarros returns readers to the world of the *Empyrean* series, which began with *Fourth Wing*. This time, it’s a set of short stories to tide fans over before the arrival of book four.

4 OUR NOBLE SELVES by Kate Atkinson

This witty historical mystery, set in 1951 against the backdrop of the Festival of Britain, tells the tale of a war-scarred journalist caught in the lives of a country rebuilding itself after the war. Having failed to resume his journalistic career, he reluctantly joins an oddball team of misfits and chancers helping to ready the festival for launch. His attempts to resume a romantic life also flounder when one of his dates goes missing and he is deemed to be the last person to have seen her alive.

5 AMERICAN HAGWON by Min Jin Lee

Waterstones head of books, Bea Carvalho, describes the

From murder mysteries to mythological tales, here are 10 books to lose yourself in this autumn

FREE FALL



Korean-American author’s novel as “a hugely ambitious multigenerational epic spanning Korea, Australia and the US and examining the pressures of the Korean educational system”. It follows the huge success of 2017’s *Pachinko*, but sticks to one couple, their children and their life in Korea, which is upended by a personal betrayal, followed by the 1997 Asian financial crisis. They move to Sydney and then

California, in search of opportunities for their children, but adjusting to life in a new land is never easy.

6 MESTRA by Madeline Miller

Buoyed by the recent release of Christopher Nolan’s film *The Odyssey*, the popularity of mythological stories isn’t waning. This new short story from the author of *The Song Of Achilles* and *Circe* now focuses on Mestra, daughter of the King of Thessaly, who is gifted the ability to shapeshift by Poseidon, and sets out to see if she can help her cursed father.

7 PECK & PECK by Bonnie Garmus

After the huge success of her debut novel *Lessons In Chemistry*, about a female chemist in misogynistic and sexist 1950s America, Garmus fast forwards to the 1980s for her second original and witty book. It features good-natured dreamer Batter Gray, who believes his future lies in poetry and joins a prestigious poetry journal called Peck & Peck, where he tries to navigate the two very different editors-in-chief and their associates.

8 ROYAL WITCH by Philippa Gregory

The internationally renowned historian and bestselling novelist, who brought us *The Other Boleyn Girl* and *Normal Women*, now sets her sights on the Royal Court of Henry V at a time when England is rich with opportunity. Young and pretty, Eleanor Cobham arrives at the court hoping for little more than to marry well, but soon sees more opportunities when she is appointed lady-in-waiting to a countess, as ancient rivalries fester.

9 VIGILAUNTIE: A MEMOIR - INNIT? by Meera Syal

Multi-award winning writer, actor and comedian Meera Syal, star of *Goodness Gracious Me* and *The Kumars at No. 42* with her husband Sanjeev Bhaskar, charts her life, from her grandfather’s attempts to arrange her marriage, to her acting and writing career, her journey to motherhood and the changing attitudes towards women that she has experienced.

10 GRUFFALO GRANNY by Julia Donaldson, Illustrated by Axel Scheffler

Donaldson is back with the third instalment in the *Gruffalo* series — the first new story in more than 20 years. It introduced Granny Gruffalo as she visits the family in the forest, full of all the original characters you know and love.

— Daily Mirror

William Shatner Reveals Why Star Trek Was a Hit, 60 Years Ago

This week marked the 60th anniversary of *Star Trek*, the sci-fi show that opened to mixed reviews, but went on to prosper — as 1,000 episodes spanning 13 series would attest. What makes this show stand the test of time? “Pure TV magic” is how the lead actor William Shatner describes it. “It was well written, and many of the episodes were extraordinary. But the fact that it was so positive about the future made people fall in love with it,” he says. “The show portrayed an existence 400 years from now that was positive, in that we’re not going to kill ourselves [through] global warming, or at this point, AI, which wasn’t thought of back then. Mankind still existed. It’s a message we need in 2026 too. Maybe more than ever. So, all those things, plus the excellence of the acting,” Shatner describes.



The star of the series says that audiences enjoyed the show’s feelings about humanity’s future

COLOURFUL CAST

Taking the helm of USS Enterprise, Shatner’s character Captain James T Kirk was joined by a diverse cast. Viewers met Mr Spock, played

by Leonard Nimoy; Lieutenant Hikaru Sulu, played by George Takei; and Lieutenant Nyota Uhura, played by Nichelle Nichols, among others. Nimoy’s Spock remains Shatner’s favourite, but he reveals things nearly turned out differently. “Spock was really interesting. And what Leonard did with it was so beautiful. *NBC* wanted to change the character completely, take off the ears, make him less exotic. And management fought that, and we won. As a result, there was this marvellously colourful character,” he adds. Inclusivity and diversity are buzzwords in the entertainment industry today, but not so much in the ‘60s. *Star Trek*’s representation, fans say, gave hope to minority viewers. “*Star Trek* was very good at showing ‘the other’ in a way that lots of things on TV didn’t at the time. It was really forward thinking. It was also at the time of the Cold War, mirroring real-world tensions and advocating for diplomacy,” Shatner says. “Writers reflect the times. The people who are writing today’s fiction have to be affected by the chaotic state of the world right now, and would reflect that in their writings, even unconsciously,” he adds.

— Daily Mirror

She Turned Breakdancing Into an Olympic Farce. Now She’s Back

A documentary revisits Rachael Gunn’s viral Olympic performance and its ensuing fallout

Les Carpenter

It’s been two years since Australian breakdancer Raygun turned her discipline’s lone Olympic appearance into a global farce. Her performance at Paris has since become a meme, a GIF showing her hopping like a kangaroo. Breakdancers thought they would find global respect after an appearance at the Olympics, perhaps even some endorsement deals to help out a profession that pays little. Their dreams crashed within minutes, as ‘B-Girl Raygun’, whose real name is Rachael Gunn, writhed around the cypher. “In what other sport is the worst performance the one everyone remembers?” asks Kateryna Pavlenko, the Ukrainian athlete who advanced to the quarterfinals in Paris. “There was real damage,” says



Rachael Gunn was coached by her husband Sammy Lee



professional breaker David Shreibman (B-Boy Kid David), who was on commentary duty that day. “I get traumatised, bro.” Now, Raygun is back. In a new documentary, she describes the horror of realising that she was a viral joke — “It was this growing monster,” she says of her newfound notoriety. “I felt my whole life crumbling in a way I never anticipated.”

BREAKDANCING TODAY The sport continues to grow despite the debacle. Longtime



breakers have noticed a surge of young dancers since the Paris Games, though Raygun remains a scar that won’t heal. They admit breaking was a strange fit for the Olympics,

dragged there by the World DanceSport Federation, which couldn’t persuade the IOC to greenlight salsa or ballroom dancing. And when it happened, Raygun dominated all coverage. Shreibman thinks she should “apologise” to other Olympic breakers. But he’s in a minority. Breakers are a supportive group, seeing themselves more as artistes and not athletes. Pavlenko knows Raygun from before the Olympics and calls her a “sweetheart”. American breaker Victor Montalvo (B-Boy Victor), who won bronze, says he was asked to appear in the documentary, but declined. Others made the same decision. “They didn’t want to add on” to the conversation about Raygun, he says. But he knows her ability. The moves she did were not what he’d seen her do before. “I was thrown off,” he says. “I have seen her break better than that.”

AUSTRALIAN CULTURE

It falls to Raygun and her husband Sammy Lee, who’s also a breaker and her coach, to answer questions. In the weeks before Paris, they realised she wasn’t as good as the other Olympians and decided to incorporate a few non-traditional dance moves to stand out. These include elements involving Australian culture, which is how she waved her arms like a swimmer, hopped like a kangaroo, and pretended to be a lawn sprinkler.

— The Washington Post

How An Erratic Monsoon Might Help Us Appreciate Weeds

FOOD FABLES



VIKRAM DOCTOR

The erratic monsoon this year has proven problematic for crops, but has been great for weeds. Short downpours followed by long periods of sunshine have resulted in places like Goa being submerged in these opportunistic plants. As soon as they are cleared with weed trimmers, a new green wave emerges. “A weed is a flower growing in the

wrong place,” wrote George Washington Carver, the great agricultural scientist. When farmers first separated plants they felt were useful — such as wheat — from those that were not, they created the category of weeds. In the *Bible*, weeds are Adam’s punishment for eating the forbidden fruit; the earth, which once was bountiful Eden, is now cursed: “Thorns also and thistles shall it bring forth to thee...”

Richard Mabey, in *Weeds: In Defense of Nature’s Most Unloved Plants*, argues that biblical farmers benefited from weeds: “The soils of the Middle East are thin and infertile... The crops roots would



have fixed them to some extent, but without the weeds that rapidly colonise disturbed soil, the bare gaps between the rows would still have been vulnerable to dust-blow, erosion and nutrient loss.”

The roots of weeds stabilised the soil, and later, their decaying plant matter helped nourish it. In Asia, weeds affected the domestication of rice differently. Water was usually abundant, and rice tolerated water-logging, so

flooding the fields helped drown weeds. Aquatic weeds remained a problem, but draining the fields stopped them, and the rice stalks could tower over new weeds. It’s a strategy which helped rice feed millions, but monsoons like this one point to the bigger problem: What happens when there’s inadequate water for flooding paddies, but enough for the weeds? Until the advent of modern herbicides, which brought their own toxic problems, the main ways to deal with weeds was cutting or eating them, either by livestock or humans. Some weeds evolved poisons to deter this, but most adapted to spread by the means used to stop them. Weeds grew very fast and produced thousands of small seeds. Seed pods would explode while their plants were being cut, or attach themselves to farmers’ clothes or the coats of animals.

Other seeds survived being eaten and, in an era where animal dung was the main fertiliser, they came up again in the fields. It’s no surprise that many farmers figured that eating weeds was the best way to live with them. Some plants, like goosefoot (*Chenopodium album*), are consumed so widely that they are part-crop, part-weed. As *bathua* in north India, it is often an essential part of *sarson ka saag*, the milder leaves helping balance the pungency of the mustard leaves. Weeds were vital for poorer communities, like the indentured Indian workers in South Africa’s sugarcane fields. ‘Cane herbs’, mostly varieties of amaranth, which grew amid the sugarcane stalks, were a free and nutritious addition to their meagre diets. Patience Gray’s remarkable *Honey from a Weed* celebrates the weed-eating traditions of the

Mediterranean. She started living on its shores long before it became a tourist destination. The villagers she lived with ate weeds partly as medicine, partly at times, like early spring, when there was little else to eat, yet partly as a delicacy in themselves relished for their bitter and sour tastes: “Washed at the fountain, they were boiled and served with oil and lemon juice.” The Mediterranean diet is much lauded for its healthiness and Gray was convinced that weed eating was at its core. Traditional Indian diets also included plants like these. During Diwali, Bengalis observe the *choddo shaak* ritual, where 14 leafy greens, both cultivated and foraged, are cooked and eaten. Rishi Panchami in western India is marked by a simple dish of boiled greens, mostly gathered wild, as the ancient *rishis* would have done in the jungles. It falls on September 15 this year and the abundant weeds of this monsoon will ensure there is plenty to cook.

VITALS

Root Weathers Storm as England Sweep Pakistan

Joe Root led from the front as England survived a major wobble to beat Pakistan by eight wickets in the third Test at Edgbaston on Saturday, sealing a 3-0 series whitewash. The home team, chasing just 130 to win, were in deep trouble when openers Ben Duckett and Emilio Gay were dismissed in the first over, bowled by Mohammad Abbas. Root, England's record runscorer, edged his first ball, bowled by Razaullah, through the slips for four in a nervy start but settled and scored quickly to take the sting out of the situation. The captain was given a huge reprieve when he chopped onto the stumps off Mohammad Ali, only for the umpire to signal a no ball, leaving the bowler distraught. Root, with Jordan Cox at the other end, had another let-off when he edged an Abbas delivery between first and second slip, with neither fielder moving. But he reached his half-century off 57 balls with a cut for four and Cox reached the landmark shortly afterwards. England reached their target in the 25th over, with Root unbeaten on 62 and Cox 59 not out. **AFP**

Wushu Player Alleges Harassment After Asian Games Snub

New Delhi: Wushu player Divyanshi Choudhary on Saturday alleged physical and mental harassment by the national federation after being dropped from India's Asian Games squad on medical grounds, claiming doctors had cleared her to compete in Japan. Divyanshi, named in India's seven-member wushu team on Aug. 22, was replaced on Friday by two-time Asian Games medalist Naorem Roshibina Devi in the women's 60kg sanda category. "I am really fed up. I have been harassed so much mentally from June, July to now, it's September, I am being harassed, because she (Roshibina) wanted to go (to the Asian Games)," she said in a video which has surfaced on social media. "Why is she not letting anyone else go? I have defeated her (in the selection trial). I have the right to go to Asian Games," said a sobbing Divyanshi. The Wushu Association of India (WAI) said an MRI showed Divyanshi had suffered a partial high-grade ACL tear with large effusion and had been advised to avoid competition and full training until recovery. Divyanshi disputed the federation's account, saying doctors had told her she could compete with her injury after taping. **PTI**

FORMULA ONE

Norris Edges Antonelli to Take Pole in 1st Spanish GP

Madrid: Formula One champion Lando Norris produced a wonder lap from out of nowhere to put McLaren on pole position for the Spanish Grand Prix at the new Madrid circuit on Saturday. Mercedes's 20-year-old championship leader Kimi Antonelli, beaten by a mere 0.011 of a second in the afternoon sunshine, joined the ecstatic Briton on the front row with Max Verstappen third fastest for Red Bull and Ferrari's Lewis Hamilton fourth. "I'm shocked. I'm a little bit surprised to be here now," exclaimed Norris in his first comments to the crowd after getting out of the car. "It was probably one of the best laps I've done ever in my career." **Reuters**

STARTING GRID		
# Driver (Team)	Time	
1. Lando Norris (McLaren)	1:31.824	
2. Kimi Antonelli (Mercedes)	1:31.835	
3. Max Verstappen (Red Bull)	1:31.964	
4. Lewis Hamilton (Ferrari)	1:32.013	
5. Charles Leclerc (Ferrari)	1:32.019	
LIVE on Fancode, 6:30pm		

A New Era for Manchester Derby After Pep's Departure

James Robson

Manchester: Pep Guardiola's departure was expected to shift the balance of power in Manchester. The early signs suggest otherwise.

For the first time in 10 years on Sunday, Manchester United go into the derby against a Manchester City no longer guided by the genius of Guardiola.

Yet, if City win at Old Trafford, the team of new manager Enzo Maresca would open an eight-point lead on United only four rounds into the Premier League season. Even this early in the campaign that would be a huge gap for United to make up.

While City are still getting used to the

change at the top after a decade of Guardiola, United have endured a carousel of managers in a desperate bid to return them to former glories.

Michael Carrick is the seventh permanent manager since the retirement of Alex Ferguson in 2013. United fans will hope Guardiola's exit will prove as profound as Ferguson's. United have not won the Premier League since Ferguson's final season in charge.

In theory, Guardiola's exit has removed the biggest barrier standing in the way of United's route back to the top following

his dominance of English football. Though he left without the title in his last two seasons, Guardiola's run of six league crowns in seven years underlined City's supremacy for the majority of his time at the club.

It would be asking a lot for Maresca — or anyone else for that matter — to emulate that level of success. Maresca, however, couldn't have made a better start to the season after a 100% winning record in the league and victory in City's opening Champions League game this week. **AP**

WATCHOUT! Tonight

PREMIER LEAGUE Man United v Man City 9pm (Star Sports) **LA LIGA** Levante v Barcelona 7:45pm; **Real Sociedad** v **Atletico Madrid** 12:30am (Fancode) **BUNDESLIGA** Elversberg v Bayern Munich 9pm (Sony Ten)



Michael Carrick (L) and Enzo Maresca

The Repeat Challenge: India's Historic Bid to Defend its Crown



Rakesh Rao

For the first time in seven decades, India is spared the burden of trying to improve upon its best-ever performance at a Chess Olympiad. Since making its debut in 1956 in what is widely considered the ultimate team competition in cerebral sport, India's goal at the 2026 edition in Samarkand, Uzbekistan (starting September 15) is simple: match the absolute best.

Following its historic double-gold sweep in Budapest in 2024, India firmly cemented its status as a global chess superpower. Since that monumental triumph, Indian chess has scaled even greater heights. D Gukesh reigns as the world champion, Divya Deshmukh is a World Cup winner, and the nation stands just one short of boasting 100 Grandmasters.

While cynics argue that team chess is merely a collection of isolated individual results — given that players battle on their own boards without active assistance from teammates — India's collective synergy is undeniable. An incredible influx of young talent propelled India from a consolation bronze in 2022 to double gold in 2024. Now, as defending champions, they carry the exhilarating pressure of a repeat performance.

THE OPEN SECTION: A FOUR-HORSE RACE

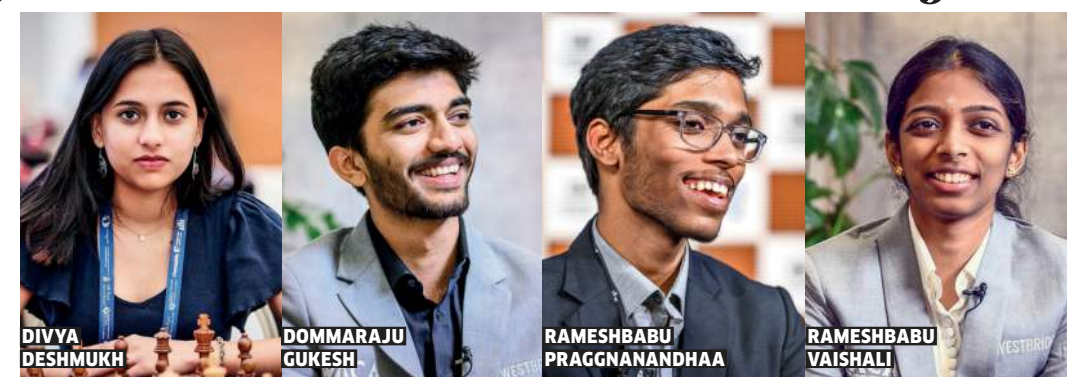
Going by the initial seedings, India is placed just behind rating-favorites USA, while heading the pack as top seeds in the women's category.

INDIA Key Players: R Praggnanandhaa, D Gukesh, Arjun Erigaisi, Nihal Sarin, Vidit Gujrathi

Outlook: Defending Champions. Possess immense firepower and luxury squad depth.

USA

Key Players: Fabiano Caruana, Wesley So, Levon Aronian



Outlook: Top Seeds. Lacking Hikaru Nakamura (absent since 2018), they look beatable and remain the team to beat.

UZBEKISTAN

Key Players: Nodirbek Abdusattorov, Jakovhir Sindarov, Nodirbek Yakubboev, Shamsiddin Volkhidov

Outlook: 2022 Champions. A dangerously young, elite squad playing with home-turf advantage.

CHINA Key Players: Wei Yi, Ding Liren, Yu Yangyi

Outlook: Heavyweights. Bringing their absolute best veterans to reclaim the ultimate prize.

THE INDIAN STRATEGY

India's lineup is pure luxury, though board order might see a tactical shake-up. While world champion Gukesh commanded the top board in the last

two editions (winning back-to-back individual golds), his recent erratic form means he enters this tournament rated fourth within the team. He could realistically anchor the third or fourth board.

Conversely, R Praggnanandhaa is in sizzling form after becoming the first Indian to win the Grand Chess Tour. Arjun Erigaisi remains a mountain of consistency. Nihal Sarin makes a welcome return, and having a seasoned grandmaster like Vidit



India are unbeaten in their last five matches against Sri Lanka **BCCL**

India's Chance To Set It Right

Harman & Co. seek to reclaim the title two years after Sri Lanka stunned them in the final

Dubai: Seven-time champions India will look to Shafali Verma and Deepti Sharma to deliver once again when they take on resilient Sri Lanka in the Women's T20 Asia Cup final on Sunday. With 168 runs, including two fifties, Shafali has been India's leading batter and the tournament's top run-scorer, unfazed by the slow, spin-friendly pitches at the Dubai International Cricket Stadium.

While Smriti Mandhana (154) has blown hot and cold, scoring a brilliant century but also making two single-digit scores, Shafali has provided greater consistency at the top of the order.

More importantly, she has played her strokes with relative ease on pitches where India's other batters have struggled.

Deepti, the tournament's joint-leading wicket-taker alongside Sri Lanka skipper Chamari Athapaththu with 11 wickets each, has spearheaded India's bowling attack and also made valuable contributions with the bat.

Her six-ball 13 in the semi-final against Bangladesh helped India push their total close to 150.

With the parsimonious Shree Charani in the mix and Prema Rawat finding her rhythm, Deepti leads a spin attack that has played a dominant role for India throughout the tournament.

Both teams are unbeaten on their way to the final, but India will be wary of a Sri Lankan side that handed them a crushing eight-wicket defeat in the final of the previous edition in 2024.

Athapaththu's team has shown the same resilience as their captain, most recently battling against the odds to beat Pakistan in the semi-final.

Reduced to 5-2 inside the first two overs and then 33-4 in the seventh, Sri Lanka refused to give up the chase of 131.

Harshitha Samarawickrama top-scored with 36 and found strong support from Kavisha Dilhari, who made 33, to revive the chase before Nilakshika Silva and Kaushini Nuthyanga held their nerve to complete the victory.

Two years ago in Dambulla, Harshitha combined with Athapaththu to defy India in the final, with both batters scoring half-centuries in a successful chase.

With many of the players from that final set to feature again, Harmanpreet Kaur's side will be determined to avoid another setback. But India have concerns of their own.

They arrived at the tournament with questions over their batting form and fielding, and while Shafali has been consistent and Mandhana scored a century two matches ago, India need greater contributions from their middle order.

Several batters have failed to convert starts, while India's inability to find boundaries regularly has also been an issue.

Fielding remains an even bigger concern. India dropped four catches in their semi-final against Bangladesh, with Pratika Rawal spilling two.

They dropped three catches against Pakistan while restricting their arch-rivals to their lowest-ever T20I total, and also put down two chances against Thailand in their tournament opener.

India have now dropped nine catches in four matches, an area they will need to address if they are to reclaim the title. **PTI**

WOMEN'S ASIA CUP FINAL

INDIA vs SRI LANKA

DUBAI INTERNATIONAL CRICKET STADIUM

FORM

WWWL WWWL

HEAD-TO-HEAD

OVERALL

25 5

IN ASIA CUP

4 1

LAST 5 MATCHES

IND won by 15 runs

IND won by 30 runs

IND won by 8 wickets

IND won by 7 wickets

IND won by 8 wickets

8pm | Sony Ten, Sony LIV

10/10

India have now reached the final in every Women's Asia Cup edition (4 ODI, 6 T20I)

Asia Cup T20 Champions

2012 India

2016 India

2018 Bangladesh

2022 India

2024 Sri Lanka

India Face Tough Selection Call

Captain Iyer will have to choose between Samson and Sooryavanshi as Afghanistan play hosts in Delhi

Kushan Sarkar

New Delhi: India face a dilemma over whether to opt for the no-holds-barred aggression of "Boy Wonder" Vaibhav Sooryavanshi or stick with the experience and flair of Sanju Samson when they take on Afghanistan in the opening game of their three-match T20I series tonight.

Sooryavanshi was drafted into the playing XI in England at Samson's expense, but by the final match of the series the 15-year-old had made way for his senior partner's return.

It is not a straightforward choice. Samson and Abhishek Sharma form a more established T20I opening pair and have done well together; but India could look to give both Samson and Sooryavanshi opportunities before finalising their squad for the Asian Games in Japan.

During Friday's evening net session, Samson appeared slightly more assured than Sooryavanshi, who received a lesson from Jasprit Bumrah on facing pace and movement off the surface. The youngster may also have needed time to adjust after playing three consecutive red-ball matches.

Sooryavanshi, however, could pose a different challenge to an Afghanistan attack that lacks a bowler of Bumrah's quality. The pace of the Afghan seamers could also suit his minimal footwork



SANJU SAMSON

IND vs AFG

FIRST T20I

ARUN JAITLEY STADIUM

FORM

WWWL WWWL

HEAD-TO-HEAD

8 0

7:30pm | Sony Ten, Sony LIV

and stand-and-deliver approach. For Samson, being dropped in England after three failures in a high-risk format appeared harsh. But Sooryavanshi's emergence gave the team management another option at the top of the order.

There is also a scenario in which both could feature if Ishan Kishan, who suffered a back injury scare during Friday's net session, is ruled out.

Kishan comes into the series on the back of an outstanding Duleep Trophy final, in which he scored 270 and 80, and will be keen to retain his place in the only format in which he is a regular for India.

For the Indian squad preparing for the Asian Games, three matches against a full-strength Afghanistan side with a world-class spin attack featuring Rashid Khan, Noor Ahmad and Mujeeb Ur Rahman would provide valuable preparation. **PTI**

Boards 2 & 3: Battle-ready Divya Deshmukh and World Championship challenger R Vaishali are expected to dominate the upper boards.

Reserve/Lower Boards: Vantika Agrawal — a crucial gold-medallist on the lower boards in 2024 — and brilliant debutant B Savitha Shri round out a formidable team.

Former champions Georgia and Kazakhstan are heavily tipped for the podium. Meanwhile, perennial heavyweights China have opted to field a fresh, experimental squad of youngsters, dropping them to the fourth seed ahead of the USA and Ukraine.

A TRULY GLOBAL SPECTACLE

The 2026 Samarkand Olympiad is shattering records. While Russia remains absent for a third consecutive edition — this time due to its chess federation's suspension — the event will feature a historic turnout:

- 205 nations in the Open section
- 190 nations in the Women's category
- 1,974 total players, including an astonishing 240 Grandmasters

In an era of hyper-competitive global sports, India enters the arena not as a hopeful challenger, but as the empire defending its crown. These players have earned their place at the top — and they deserve every bit of support.